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'NO MEETING HELD BY TRUST TO DISCUSS PROPOSAL'

Kept in Dark about Tata Sons Recast Plan: SDTT Trustees

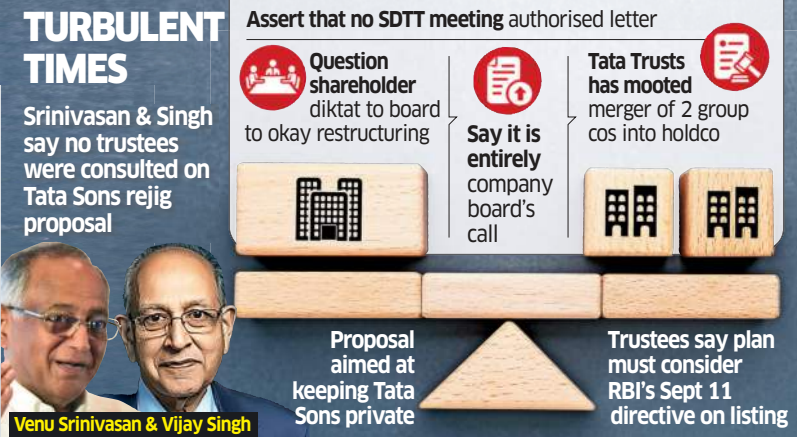
Srinivasan, Vijay Singh claim to have been caught unawares by Tata Trusts' letter sent to holdco

Kala Vijayraghavan & Sagar Malviya

Mumbai: Tata Trusts has seen a fresh rift over a proposal to reorganise Tata Sons, with two Sir Dorabji Tata Trust (SDTT) trustees — Venu Srinivasan and Vijay Singh — saying in a September 30 letter to other trustees they were not consulted before a letter supporting the plan was sent to the Tata Group holding company. Srinivasan and Vijay Singh — SDTT vice chairmen — said they were surprised to receive a copy of a September 28 letter to the Tata Sons board and learn about an accompanying press release from public sources.

ET first broke the story in its online edition.

"No meeting of the Trustees of SDTT was held to discuss or deliberate on this issue before the letter was sent to Tata Sons and neither were they aware whether the other trustees had been consulted," the two trustees said in a letter. The letter wanted the Tata Sons board to



approve a reorganisation involving the merger of Tata Electronics Systems Solutions and Tata Consulting Engineers into Tata Sons. The objective was for Tata Sons to cease being a core investment company and a press release announcing the proposal was issued the same day in the name of the "Tata Trusts," the trustees said. They said neither the letter nor the press release could be considered the collective position of the trust as no meeting had authorised them.

Ripple Effects >> 10

ALLEGED DEFAULT OF ₹4.31 CR Insolvency Plea Against Shapoorji Pallonji Binned

The NCLT has rejected a petition filed by Uniton Infra seeking initiation of bankruptcy proceedings against Shapoorji Pallonji & Co over an alleged default of ₹4.31 crore, report **Kailash Babar & Maulik Vyas**. >> 11

RBI OKAYS 3-YR TERM FOR INCOMING CHIEFS

Bagchi to Head HDFC Bank; Saha in Kotak Cockpit



ANUP KUMAR SAHA
Kotak Mahindra Bank CEO & MD

ANUP BAGCHI
HDFC Bank CEO & MD

Both are former ICICI Bank execs and IIT alumni

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Two of India's largest private-sector lenders, HDFC Bank and Kotak Mahindra Bank, Thursday named new managing directors and chief executives, ending weeks of speculation over leadership succession at two entities that routinely feature on the shopping lists of several foreign institutional investors (FII).

HDFC Bank appointed Anup Bagchi, former managing director and CEO of ICICI Prudential Life Insurance, as its next MD and CEO. Earlier in

the day, Kotak Mahindra Bank named Anup Saha, currently an executive director and whole-time director at the bank, for the top post. Both have been appointed for three years each following approvals by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI). Bagchi, 56, will take charge after Sashidhar Jagdishan's six-year term ends on October 26. Jagdishan had decided not to seek reappointment at India's most-valued lender.

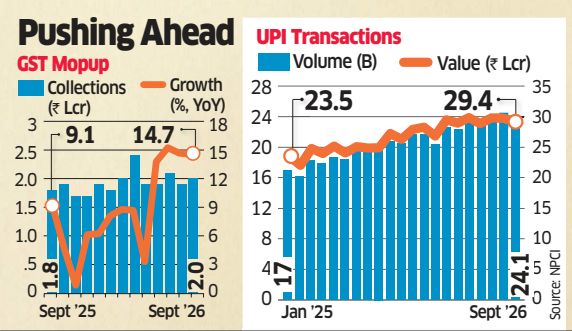
Saha, 55, will assume office on January 1, succeeding Ashok Vaswani, who also chose not to seek a second term at the Uday Kotak-founded bank.

Vast Experience >> 10

GST MOPUP RISES 14.7% IN SEPT

Strong Macro Show Takes Shape in Q2 before Festive Rush

Car sales and power demand also robust



Our Bureau

New Delhi: India's economy ended the second quarter of fiscal 2027 on a strong footing with several high-frequency indicators pointing to robust growth in September. Economists expect the momentum to continue, with the festive season providing further impetus to economic activity in the coming months.

Goods and services tax collections rose 14.7% on-year to ₹2.04 lakh crore in September, aided by domestic consumption and strong growth in revenue from imports. Collections remained above the ₹2 lakh crore mark for the third consecutive month. The steady growth in domestic collections, despite geopolitical tensions, and festive season are likely to support GST revenue over next three months, said tax experts.

Car sales recorded strong double-digit growth, with estimates suggesting a 21% ye-

ar-on-year increase to 460,000 units last month as automakers ramped up dispatches to meet anticipated festive-season demand.

Transaction volumes on UPI grew 22.6% from a year earlier to 24.07 billion, while transaction value increased 18%.

Transaction volumes, however, were slightly lower than the record levels seen in August as the payments ecosystem adjusts to upcoming changes in the merchant discount rate framework. Manufacturing activity also remained robust, with strong domestic and international demand driving growth in new orders and output. The HSBC Purchasing Managers Index rose to a seven-month high of 55.1 in September from 52.8 in August. A reading above 50 indicates expansion in economic activity.

www.economictimes.com

HIGHER THAN RBI FORECAST

Finmin Pegs Sept Qtr Growth at 7.3%

The finance ministry has projected a 7.3% increase in gross domestic product (GDP) in the September quarter, higher than the 6.4% forecast by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI). >> 7

FLUSH WITH FCNR FLOWS

Rate Hike to Help Banks Push FY27 Profitability

A likely rise in benchmark interest rates by RBI next week, along with liquidity from FCNR(B) deposits, will help boost banks' profitability for the rest of the fiscal. **Joel Rebello** reports. >> 9

AI-ENABLED SERVICE

Govt Close to Picking Digilocker Integrators

The government is close to empaneling private AI integrators to widen the DigiLocker ecosystem, and bring in more institutions who use the platform. **Subhayan Chakraborty** reports. >> 13

IT Firms Reboot Fresher Hiring, but Experienced Pros Hold Upper Hand

Graduate-level recruitment may reach up to 135,000 this fiscal, 23% higher on-year

Beena Parmar

Bengaluru: India's \$300 billion technology and IT services industry is seeing a revival in fresher onboarding after several years of subdued hiring,

according to industry estimates. However, the share of entry-level staff is trailing that of mid-level professionals, reflecting robust demand for experienced AI talent.

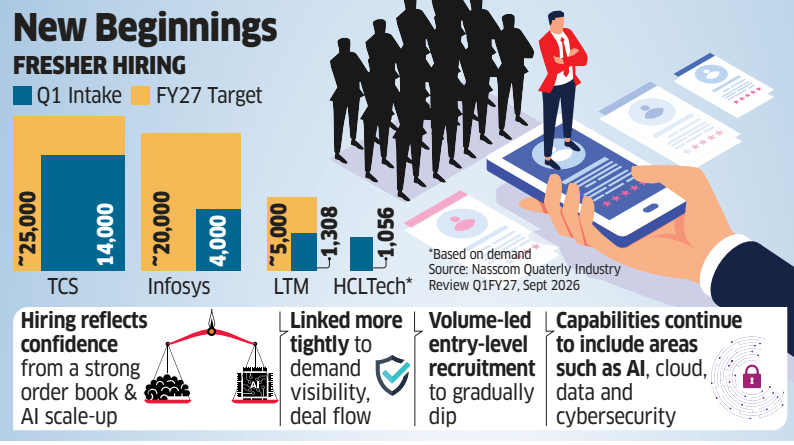
Fresher hiring, which fell to a record low of around 110,000 in FY26, will

reach 115,000 to 135,000 this fiscal year, according to recruitment firm Qness Group's estimates. This marks a likely increase of 4.5-22.7%.

Fresher or graduate-level hiring had been declining steadily, slipping to 125,000 in FY25, from 155,000 in FY24, 250,000 in FY23 and 380,000 in FY22. Fresher hiring rebounded in the June quarter from the quarter before, as Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), Infosys and HCLTech recruited about 19,000 entry-level staff, industry body Nasscom said in its September quarter report covering data from 29 IT services firms.

Largest global IT giant Accenture on Thursday reported stronger than expected earnings for the quarter and FY26 ending August. It also predicted revenues to grow more quickly with a target of 3-6% growth for the new fiscal year starting September. The company's outlook propelled sentiment for the whole industry with ADRs of Infosys and Wipro rising almost 10% in early trade.

Higher Bar for Entry-level Talent >> 10



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Captain Smit Machchhar
SAVED 174 LIVES

In the face of the gravest danger and despite being seriously injured, he showed immense courage and an unwavering resolve to protect the lives of others: **MODI**

I salute Indian Captain Smit Machchhar, the crew, and all who showed extraordinary courage and presence of mind under attack, helping save precious lives: **KHARGE**

Indian Muslim League leader Panakkad Sayyid Munavvar Ali Shihab Thangal says Captain Smit protected several lives through his 'extraordinary courage and presence of mind', hails the pilot's 'timely intervention and great service'



Gujarat govt announces 'Visisht Gujarat Garima Award' for Captain Smit

Captain Smit Machchhar airlifted to Abu Dhabi for advanced medical care after suffering stab wounds

Captain Smit Machchhar is in good health and recovering well. Indian ambassador to the UAE visited the pilot in hospital **INDIAN EMBASSY IN THE UAE**

Prayers held in several prominent temples in India, including at Somnath and Kashi Vishwanath, for Captain's good health

All of India is Vith ya!



Amul Breakfast without hurdles

'PREVENTED ANOTHER 9/11 LIKE TRAGEDY'

PM Lauds Capt Smit's Courageous Act

Captain Smit displayed patience, wisdom and courage... Smit's heroism fills every citizen with pride: Modi

PM SPEAKS TO FAMILY



Today, I spoke with his father, Bhupendra Bhai, his mother, Geeta Bhabhi, and his wife, Sonal. He is undergoing treatment, and the entire world is proud of him. I urge our countrymen to pray for Smit's long life and good health, and to congratulate brother Smit, who has brought glory to India

NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Prime Minister Narendra Modi lauded the brave act of Captain Smit Machchhar, who fought and prevented his co-pilot from hijacking the Flydubai aircraft, saving the lives of 170 passengers and crew on Thursday, and underlined that he stopped a 9/11 like attack from taking place. Addressing bureaucrats at the centenary celebrations of Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) here, the prime minister praised Captain Machchhar for his act without fearing for his life. "The incident that took place yesterday and the manner in which India's Captain Smit displayed patience, wisdom and courage... and as the Israeli prime minister said 'an Indian has prevented another 9/11 like tragedy from happening'... Smit's heroism fills every citizen with pride." Modi said he spoke to Captain Machchhar's parents and wife and the whole nation is praying for his quick recovery. "Today, I spoke with his father, Bhupendra Bhai, his mother, Geeta Bhabhi, and his wife, Sonal. He is undergoing treatment, and the entire world is

A SUDDEN WAVE OF PRIDE AND ANXIETY WHERE SMIT MACHCHHAR GREW UP

Speedy Recovery of 'Global Hero' Pilot is Mumbai Neighbourhood's Main Concern

When I wear uniform, then there is no nonsense. You just do your job: **Smit in a podcast in 2025**

Our Political Bureau

Mumbai: In a quiet corner of suburban Mumbai, the headlines that Captain Smit Machchhar was making globally have brought a sudden wave of pride and anxiety to the neighbourhood where he grew up. At Swastik Heights Society in Chembur where Machchhar's parents live, neighbours have been checking in on the family since late Wednesday evening, when news broke of the dramatic incident involving the Flydubai pilot. "He is now a global hero, but we are concerned about his safety and wish him a speedy recovery," said neighbour Kailash Gandhi. Machchhar, 39, was the pilot onboard Flydubai flight FZ1073, a Boeing 737 MAX 8 flying from Dubai to Tel Aviv, which diverted to Tabuk in Saudi Arabia after reportedly plunging to around 14,000 feet. According to reports, the co-pilot, an Omani national, attacked Machchhar and tried to crash the aircraft. As news of the incident spread, ne-

ighbours began arriving at the Machchhar residence. His wife and children live with him in Dubai while his parents are in Mumbai. "When we heard the news and learnt that his parents had also been asked to fly to Saudi Arabia, I decided to drop them at the airport," said neighbour Akshay Doshi. But for the residents of Swastik Heights, Machchhar is the boy they watched grow up in Mumbai. Machchhar grew up in Ghatkopar East. His parents had migrated to



Residents and well-wishers outside the pilot's residence in Mumbai - PTI

"The parents looked tense, and rightly so, during the journey. As neighbours, it is our job to pitch in during an emergency. He is now a

national hero and all we want is for him to recover quickly," Doshi said. Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu said the injured captain fought back and succeeded in opening the cockpit door, allowing passengers and crew to restrain the attacker. Flydubai said its crew took control of the situation and secured the aircraft. But for the residents of Swastik Heights, Machchhar is the boy they watched grow up in Mumbai. Machchhar grew up in Ghatkopar East. His parents had migrated to

aviation seminar at the age of 19 set him on a completely different path. While his mother was apprehensive about his decision to pursue a career in aviation, his father encouraged him to follow his ambition. His brother later followed in his footsteps, becoming a commercial pilot. He studied in Mumbai, including at the Welinkar Institute of Management in Matunga, before travelling to New Zealand for pilot training. He returned to India and spent 11 years operating from Mumbai for SpiceJet, having joined the airline in 2011. By November 2020, he had risen to the position of Line Training Captain, a role that involved training and assessing other pilots.

In June 2022, he moved to Dubai to join Flydubai, where he lives with his wife and two children. In a podcast in 2025, Machchhar spoke about the discipline he brought to his profession and his effort to keep his work life separate from his family life. "When I wear the uniform, then there is no nonsense. You just do your job," he had said. On Wednesday, that uniform — and the man who wore it — was thrust into the glare of international headlines. As he fights to recover, an entire community prays for his safe return home.

CONGRESS PRESIDENT WISHES HIM A 'SWIFT & FULL RECOVERY' Salute Captain Smit Machchhar: Kharge

NEW DELHI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday hailed Smit Machchhar after he thwarted his co-pilot's alleged attempt to crash a flydubai flight, and wished him a swift and full recovery. "I salute Indian Captain Smit Machchhar, the crew, and all who showed extraordinary courage and presence of mind under attack, helping



save precious lives," Kharge said on X. "Wishing Captain Machchhar a swift and full recovery," he said. The flight was carrying 174 passengers, including 27 children. - PTI



LETTER TO SPEAKER Make JPC Do its Job on FCRA Bill: Venugopal to Birla

'There is intention to have the bill passed hastily'

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Congress MP KC Venugopal has written a letter to Speaker Om Birla on Thursday, complaining that the joint parliamentary committee scrutinising the Foreign Contribution Regulation (FCRA) Amendment Bill has not done enough consultations with the stakeholders, even when there is indication of the government's intent to get the bill passed in the next Parliament session. He urged the Speaker not to take up the bill until JPC, even through an extended term, does a detailed examination and gives enough opportunities to stakeholders to place their concerns before it. "It has, however, been learnt that no meaningful consultation with stakeholders is taking place, and that there is an intention to have the bill passed hastily in the forthcoming winter session," he wrote.

CALCUTTA HC TOLD TO EXPEDITE HEARING; APEX COURT: WON'T EXAMINE MERITS OF DISPUTE OVER 4 ACCOUNTS

SC Refuses to Interfere With Freeze on Bank Accounts of Trinamool Congress

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to lift the debit freeze on four bank accounts of Trinamool Congress (TMC) and asked the Calcutta High Court to expedite the hearing of the party's plea challenging the freeze. A bench of justices MM Sundresh and PB Varale said it was not inclined to exercise its jurisdiction under Article 136 at this stage. It made it clear that it was refraining from examining the merits of the dispute. "We refrain from going into the merits. We are not inclined to exercise our jurisdiction under Article 136. We request the high court to expedite the hearing," the bench said. The top court was hearing Mamata Banerjee-led TMC's challenge to the freezing of four Indian Bank accounts following a complaint by a member of rival faction of the party. Senior advocate Abhishek Manu

FUNCTIONING AS AN MP IMPEDED: MAHUA MOITRA SC Seeks Responses from Centre, Bengal to Moitra's Petition Over MPLADS Works



NEW DELHI: SC has sought responses from the Centre and Bengal government on a plea filed by TMC MP Mahua Moitra, alleging obstruction in the implementation of works under the Member of Parliament Local Area Development Scheme (MPLADS) in her Krishnanagar constituency. Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana were hearing Moitra's plea, alleging that her functioning as an MP had been impeded, including through difficulties in carrying out MPLADS-related works and accessing facilities during visits to her constituency. - OPB

Singhvi, appearing for TMC, sought interim relief, contending that the freeze was paralysing the functioning of the political party. He said that the four accounts involved in the present proceedings were distinct from three HDFC Bank accounts that had earlier been frozen in connection

with a separate proceeding and were subsequently permitted to be operated under the supervision of an administrator for day-to-day expenses. "The paralysis occurs because my audited accounts show day-to-day expenses. No political expenses. Every day a political party's oxygen is para-

lysed. Byelections are coming," Singhvi said. He said TMC requires at least ₹12.15 crore a month to sustain its operations, apart from expenses relating to byelections and legal costs. **ABHISHEK MANU SINGHVI** Senior Advocate

lysed. Byelections are coming," Singhvi said. He said TMC requires at least ₹12.15 crore a month to sustain its operations, apart from expenses relating to byelections and legal costs. The bench suggested that the court-appointed administrator who had been supervising the operation of the earlier accounts could also deal with the four Indian Bank accounts that have been frozen. Singhvi agreed to the suggestion. The court, however, declined to pass any order permitting operation of the accounts.

Tiger to Roar Once Again in Buxa Reserve

A tigress from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve set to be released into Alipurduar forests today

Jayatri Nag

Kolkata: A tigress, translocated from Bihar's Valmiki Tiger Reserve, will be released into the Buxa Tiger Reserve in north Bengal's Alipurduar district on Friday. Buxa currently has no tigers. The tigress was brought by an IAF aircraft to Hasimara airbase and then taken by road to a designated enclosure inside the Buxa reserve. It is likely to be released into the wild by Union minister Bhupendra Yadav and CM Suvedu Adhikari on Friday. "This is happening for the first time



'This is happening for the first time in Bengal and eastern India, and is a major milestone'

in Bengal and eastern India, and is a major milestone. The release of the tigress has immense importance for the Dooars in north Bengal," state forest minister Manoj Oraon told ET.

"In our Dooars region, we speak about three 'Ts' — timber, tea and tourism. Among these, tourism is a key factor. The tea gardens are not in good condition and are shutting down. If



Tigers disappeared from Buxa due to human activities: Manoj Oraon

gters gradually disappeared from Buxa due to human activities. We must restore their habitat. To stabilise the ecological pyramid, we must sustain those at the top".

EX-BENGAL CM TARGETS CEC AS 'VANISH KUMAR'

Mamata and Abhishek Allege ECI Handed Over 150 Seats to BJP

I challenge Election Commission to prove us wrong: Abhishek

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Former West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee and her party's general secretary Abhishek Banerjee on Thursday stepped up their attack on the Election Commission of India, alleging serious irregularities in the electoral roll revision and counting process in the state, with the latter claiming that deletions exceeded winning margins in around 150 assembly seats. The two leaders addressed a joint press conference here in the presence of several of their party MPs, including Derek O'Brien and Dola Sen. Abhishek alleged that the deletions, including cases categorised as 'logical discrepancy', were greater than the eventual winning margin in around 150 seats and claimed these constituencies were "effectively handed to BJP through this process". "I challenge the Election Commission to prove us wrong by putting the complete records in public domain and allowing independent examination of the process," he said. Mamata also targeted chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, calling him "Vanish Kumar", questioning the statutory immunity provided to the CEC and election commissioners under the 2023 law. "He made people's rights vanish. How can I forgive him? It is the people of India who will not forgive him," she said. She alleged that the special intensive revision (SIR) had disproportionately affected constituencies won by her party.



SLAMMING ECI People Can Question SIR Ordered After Decades: High Court

PANAJI: Bombay High Court on

Thursday said that the primary mandate of the Election Commission is to ensure citizens cast their votes, and asserted that while the election body questions voter conduct, citizens are equally within their rights to ask why exercises like SIR are ordered after decades. Hearing a petition filed by six family members whose names were deleted from the voter list, HC's Goa bench, comprising justices Valmiki Menezes and Amit S Jamsandekar, said the **ECI's action was not in consonance with its mandate.** - PTI

EARLIER, UAE-BASED ACCUSED MANVEER RAM WAS HELD FOR ALLEGEDLY SUPPLYING WEAPONS USED IN KILLING

NIA Arrests UAE-Deported Financier for Targeted Killing of VHP Leader in 2024

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has arrested Harwinder Kumar alias Sonu in connection with the targeted killing of local Vishwa Hindu Parishad (VHP) leader Vikas Prabhakar. The accused, who was based in the UAE, was involved in providing logistical support and financing to the perpetrators and had been wanted by the NIA, the agency said in a statement on Thursday.



NIA officials escort accused Harwinder Kumar at IGI Airport – IANS

Kumar was deported from the UAE to India on October 1, 2026 after diplomatic efforts. Following his arrival, he was arrested by the NIA at the Indira Gandhi International Airport. He was produced before

the Special NIA Court for further legal proceedings.

The case pertains to the targeted killing of Prabhakar by members of the proscribed terrorist organisation

Babbar Khalsa International (BKI). NIA had registered the case on May 9, 2024, and has so far filed three chargesheets in the matter, NIA said.

The present arrest follows the arrest of another UAE-based accused, Manveer Ram, on August 13, 2026. Ram, who was allegedly involved in supplying weapons used in the crime, was intercepted at Amritsar Airport and subsequently arrested by the NIA.

NIA investigation has revealed that the conspiracy to eliminate Vikas Prabhakar was allegedly hat-

ched by Germany-based BKI operatives Harjit Singh and Kulbeer Singh. Investigation has established that Kumar, while operating from the UAE, played a crucial role as a logistics provider and financier for the BKI operatives based abroad.

He acted as a recruiter and handler, arranged weapons and facilitated their delivery to the shooters involved in Prabhakar's killing. He also received and transferred terror funds in connection with the conspiracy, acting on the directions of Harjit Singh and Kulbeer Singh. Kumar's deportation and his subsequent arrest demonstrate the NIA's resolve to pursue fugitives involved in terrorism cases and bring them back to India to face the due process of law, NIA stated.

SEEKS FIR, STATEWIDE PROBE

DKS Stages Dharna at ECI Office over Bulk Form 7 Filings

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Thursday staged a dharna outside the Election Commission of India (ECI) office in Bengaluru along with his Cabinet colleagues, accusing the BJP of filing Form 7 applications in bulk to seek deletion of voters from Karnataka's electoral rolls.

Shivakumar demanded registration of an FIR and a time-bound, statewide probe into the alleged misuse of Form 7 during the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. He met chief electoral officer V Anbukumar and submitted a letter demanding immediate action and a probe into specific cases flagged. The CM and ministers

stayed at the CEO's office for a long time, putting off a Cabinet meeting scheduled for the afternoon.

"As the chief minister of Karnataka, it is my bounden duty to protect the right of every eligible voter and ensure that the SIR process is free, fair, transparent and legally compliant," Shivakumar said.

The CM said about 6,259 Form 7 applications in Mudigere, about 3,000 in Belagavi North, 2,285 in Bhal-ki, 1,373 in Babaleshwar and 1,200 in Narasimharaja had been filed, pointing out that large number of such forms had been reported on Septem-

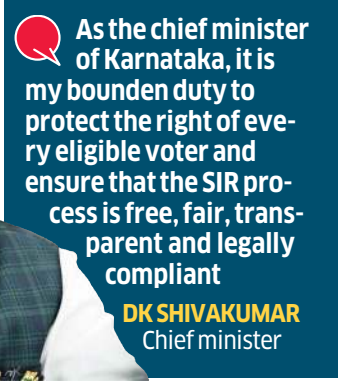
ber 22, 23 and 24. Shivakumar alleged that a substantial number of voters targeted for deletion belonged to minority communities, SCs, STs and OBCs. He also flagged cases where voter names and EPIC numbers were pre-printed on Form 7 applications, raising questions about the source and possible misuse of electoral data.

The CM had earlier alleged that pre-printed forms were being circulated and claimed that about 50 lakh such forms had been printed.

Home minister Priyank Kharge also alleged that Form 7 applications carrying voter details were being supplied in bulk.

Shivakumar has sought an inquiry into individuals filing unusually large numbers of objections, their relationship with the voters concerned, applications returned by booth level officers (BLOs) and any political coordination or facilitation behind the filings.

Meanwhile, Anbukumar directed election officials to initiate action against applicants found to have knowingly made false statements or declarations in electoral forms, amid allegations of bulk filing of Form-7 applications to delete names of eligible voters, adds PTI.



As the chief minister of Karnataka, it is my bounden duty to protect the right of every eligible voter and ensure that the SIR process is free, fair, transparent and legally compliant. DK SHIVAKUMAR Chief minister

TERMS FOR PERSONS WITH DISABILITIES

Census Repeats 'Nihshakt' Term Used in 2011, Activists Object

Nidhi Sharma

New Delhi: Disability rights activists have objected to being termed as "nihshakt" (or incapable) in the ongoing Census 2027 exercise and have red-flagged it as "derogatory" and "illegal". India has been using "divyangjan" in Hindi for persons with disabilities since 2016.

The home ministry's gazette notification in Hindi, dated August 14, 2026, lays down that the census officers will be collecting information on 40 parameters. On serial number 13, the notification lays down "nihshaktata" (translated to incapacity) as one of the parameters. While the English translation terms it as "disability", the Hindi description has raised the hackles of disability rights activists.

Speaking to ET, Akeel Ahmad Usmani, founder of Disability Rights Advocacy Group, said, "This usage is derogatory and defunct. It also violates the government's own law — the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act 2016. The government has been using the term 'divyang' for persons with disabilities."

Activists say the Registrar General of India, the authority for conducting the Census, has copied the 2011 Census parameters. "In 2011, the word used was 'nihshaktata'. But then the

current laws were not in place. The Registrar General seems to have simply copied the parameters without being mindful of the laws. At that time, disability was at serial no.9, now



BY MISTAKE: RGI
RGI says 'nihshakt' use in gazette inadvertent; 'divyangata' used in enumeration form

at 13," he said. When this was flagged to the authorities by ET, an official of the RGI office said, "Earlier use of 'nihshakt' in the enumeration form as in the last Census is an inadvertent error. Currently, 'divyangata' is being used in the enumeration form." The government may need to notify this in the gazette since the word has been mentioned in the notification.

India is a signatory to the United Nations Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities (UNCPRD) and had formulated Rights of Per-

sons with Disabilities Act 2016 to align its legislation to its international commitments. **Prime Minister had used the term "divyangjan" for the first time on December 3, 2015 while launching Accessible India Campaign, India's flagship mission to make its public infrastructure disabled-friendly.**

He had spoken about it extensively in his 'Mann Ki Baat' episode aired on December 27, 2015 paving the way for the government to make the usage official in 2016. The nodal department in the government of India was formed in 2012, under the ministry of social justice and empowerment, and called "department of disability affairs". However, it was renamed "Divyangjan Sashaktikaran Vibhag" to align with the government's flagship programme.

Executive director, NCPEDP, Arman Ali (disability rights advocate) said, "This opportunity to get counted has come after 15 years.... Digital self-enumeration is an opportunity to not leave anyone behind, but our attempts to get information or awareness initiatives have not been heard."

A questionnaire sent to DPDPd went unanswered. A government official, who did not wish to be identified, told ET, "The language and terminology has evolved. The government's commitment is visible in how it has named the department and all its official documents."

VIA M'LURU, UDUPI

B'luru Gets Direct Vande Bharat Connectivity to Goa

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: Rail connectivity between Bengaluru, coastal Karnataka and Goa received a major boost with the extension of the existing Madgaon-Mangaluru Vande Bharat Express to Bengaluru via Hassan, Udupi and Karwar.

The move follows Union minister for heavy industries and steel HD Kumaraswamy urging railway minister Ashwini Vaishnaw to introduce a Vande Bharat service connecting Bengaluru and Madgaon through Hassan, Mangaluru Junction, Udupi and Karwar.

In his representation, Kumaraswamy highlighted the growing importance of the corridor for tourists, pilgrims, students and professionals, while stressing the need for stronger links between Bengaluru and the commercial, port and tourism hubs of coastal Karnataka and Goa.

Responding to the proposal, Vaishnaw informed Kumaraswamy that the existing Madgaon-Mangaluru Vande Bharat Express has been extended up to Bengaluru along the same route.

Patients often billed at or near MRP despite hospitals procuring at heavy discounts

Our Political Bureau

Bengaluru: The state government has urged the Centre to address steep mark-ups on cancer drugs, medical devices and hospital consumables after inspections found patients were often billed at or near the maximum retail price (MRP) despite hospitals procuring products at heavily discounted institutional rates.

The state government has shared its findings with the Union ministry of health and family welfare and the National Pharmaceutical Pricing Authority (NPPA), seeking measures to improve transparency and curb excessive patient billing, an of-

ficial statement said.

Inspections conducted by the Food Safety and Drug Administration (FSDA) across hospitals, including cancer treatment facilities, revealed wide gaps between procurement costs and patient charges. The department said mark-ups ranged from 10 times to more than 52 times the actual acquisition cost in several cases, it added.

The state identified pricing anomalies in 253 medicines and consumables. Among the examples cited, Gufipol was procured at ₹86 but carried an MRP of ₹4,528, while Guficycline-50 Injection was bought at ₹160 against an MRP of ₹7,110. Terlitis was supplied at ₹118 and retailed at ₹4,416.

The statement also highlighted substantial price differentials in high-value oncology medicines. Taxocare 120 mg was procured at around ₹1,000 against an MRP of ₹21,617, while Can-mab 440 mg had a landing cost of ₹6,600 compared with an MRP of ₹57,457. Bevatax 400 mg Injection was supplied at ₹5,850 against an MRP of ₹62,690, and Cytax 100 mg was purchased at ₹342 against an MRP of ₹3,836.

Similar disparities were found in hospital consumables. An adult nebuliser mask procured at ₹14.50 carried an MRP of ₹950, while an IV set purchased at ₹14.75 was priced at ₹295.

Acting on health minister UT Khader's directions, FSDA enforcement officers conducted a fresh verification drive on September 25-26 across hospitals, wholesale drug establishments and healthcare facilities in Bengaluru and other districts. The exercise covered more than 768 consumables and 189 high-cost medicines, with preliminary findings again indicating large differences between landing costs, MRPs and sale price, the statement added.

Sports World Play

Ronaldo Walks Out of Portugal Camp Over Benching, Future in Doubt

Uncertainty surrounds the future of Portugal superstar Cristiano Ronaldo in the national team after the 41-year-old walked out on the squad following an announcement from coach Jorge Jesus that he would not start Thursday's game against Denmark.

Ronaldo announced late Wednesday that he had left the team, shortly after a press conference in which Jesus confirmed the five-time Ballon d'Or winner would be left out of his starting line-up for a second consecutive game.

Portugal's record goalscorer said that "in time" he would "tell the



Portuguese people the truth about the reasons" behind his departure. "Following the national team coach's news conference, and after a conversation with the president of the Portuguese football federation, I decided to leave the national team's training camp," the 41-year-old said on Instagram, adding that he has always "dedicated" himself to the side.

"Now is the time to wish good luck to

Cristiano Ronaldo leaves

lowed him there in an attempt to persuade him to remain in Copenhagen but failed to change his mind, Spanish newspaper Marca reported.

The FFP disciplinary code states that national team players who leave without permission can be subject to a suspension of one to six months from the Portugal national team.

Jesus said earlier that against Denmark he again intended to start AC Milan striker Goncalo Ramos, who scored the winner in Norway. "I need him (Ronaldo), he won't." Agencies

VITALS

ODI WORLD CUP 2027

India, Australia and Pakistan in Same Group

Guwahati: India will meet defending champions Australia and bitter rivals Pakistan in their first two matches at the 2027 Cricket World Cup, the ICC announced on Thursday. The India-Australia match, a repeat of the 2023 final, will be in Cape Town on October 7 and the India-Pakistan clash will take place in Johannesburg three days later. The tournament, hosted by South Africa, Zimbabwe and Namibia, will start on October 4 and the final will be played on November 27. Afghanistan, Zimbabwe and a qualifier will also be in India's Group. AFP

There has to be a bit more contest between bat and ball. This is not cricket, this is only batting GAUTAM GAMBHIR Indian men's cricket team's coach on 400-run chase

Five-run Penalty for Batters Wasting Time: ICC

Batters found to be wasting time three times or more can now incur a five-run penalty for their team, the ICC said on Thursday, announcing a series of changes to its playing conditions. "If a batter is not ready to face the ball within the prescribed time, a warning will be issued for the first offence, a final warning for the second, and five penalty runs awarded to the fielding side for the third and each subsequent offence," the ICC said. The governing body has also allowed pink balls to be trialled in day Tests by mutual agreement between the teams. Reuters

The Great Escape

India survive Pakistan scare to enter final, will face Malaysia in title clash

Ajai Masand

Defending champions India survived a dramatic second-half fight-back from arch-rivals Pakistan before Abhishek scored with 45 seconds remaining to secure a 4-3 victory and reach the Asian Games hockey final on Thursday.

India will face Malaysia in the gold-medal match on Saturday after the Malaysians beat South Korea in the other semifinal.

Captain Harmanpreet Singh converted penalty corners in the fifth and 13th minutes before Sukhjeet Singh added a field goal in the 23rd to put India 3-0 ahead.

Pakistan hit back through Abu Mahmood just before halftime, Hannan Shahid in the 45th minute and Waheed Rana four minutes later to level the contest.

With the match heading towards a shootout, Abhishek produced the decisive touch in the final minute, his effort taking a



India and Pakistan players after the match

MEDALS TALLY				
#	COUNTRY	G	S	B
1.	China	154	71	63
2.	Japan	59	79	73
3.	South Korea	30	30	217
4.	Uzbekistan	16	21	19
5.	Iran	12	17	13
8.	India	10	23	31

LIVE on Sony Sports Network

deflection off Pakistan defender Sufiyan and beating goalkeeper Ali Raza.

India dominated the opening half, pinning Pakistan deep in their own half and creating a series of penalty corners.

Harmanpreet opened the scoring with a powerful drag-flick after India had failed to convert their first four set pieces. The skipper doubled the lead eight minutes later, firing home another penalty corner after a run down the left by Manpreet Singh earned India their seventh opportunity.

Sukhjeet made it 3-0 in the 23rd minute when he tapped in after Shilanand Lakra delivered a precise pass from the left of the goal-line.

The defending champions will now have to regroup quickly for Saturday's final against Malaysia.

INDIA DEMOLISH SRI LANKA

The Shreyas Iyer-led Indian T20 side was short on both practice and game time for their semifinal against Sri Lanka. But that hardly mattered when the action began as the Indians first posted a daunting 169/7 on the difficult track before dismissing the Lankans for a record low of 45 runs to march into the finals. The win was built around a 46-ball unbeaten 80 by Ishan Kishan and the brilliance of Jasprit Bumrah and Axar Patel, both of whom picked up two wickets a piece. Pakistan await India in the final after beating Bangladesh in the other semifinal. PTI

288 PROPERTIES ATTACHED 4,000 Held in J&K Drug Crackdown Since April: DGP

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: More than 4,000 people involved in the drug trade have been arrested in Jammu and Kashmir as part of the 'Nasha Mukht Abhiyan' (drug free campaign) launched in April, director general of police (DGP) Nalin Prabhat said on Thursday.

Addressing participants at the 'Run for Unity' in Srinagar, Prabhat said police had registered 3,257 drug-related cases since April 11, when lieutenant governor Manoj Sinha launched the campaign from Jammu. He said that 170 convictions had been secured and more than 2,500 cases had already been disposed of. "In terms of property attachments, J&K currently ranks number one across India, with 288 properties worth ₹138 crore attached, while ₹80 lakh cash was seized," he said. The DGP said that 144 accused persons had been booked under the Prevention of Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, the highest for any state or union territory in the country. The 'Nasha Mukht Yuva for Viksit Bharat Sankalp Abhiyan' is aimed at eradicating substance abuse among the youth.

Swiss President to Visit India as FTA With EFTA Marks First Anniversary

Dipanjana Roy Chaudhary

New Delhi: Swiss President Guy Parmelin will undertake a state visit to New Delhi early next week to mark one year of a free trade agreement between India and the European Free Trade Association (EFTA) countries.

This will be Parmelin's second visit to New Delhi this year as Switzerland looks to accelerate investments in India and also prepares to host the AI Summit in Geneva in 2027, taking forward the agenda of the Indian edition of the AI Summit held in February.

AI has emerged as the new area of cooperation between India and Switzerland. The Swiss government has said it wants the 2027 summit to address the international governance of AI and the role of international law and fundamental rights in the development and use of the technology.

Parmelin will hold a summit meeting with Prime Minister Narendra Modi. The visit is also expected to provide an opportunity to further strengthen bilateral cooperation, particularly in trade, investment, technology, innovation and emerging areas of strategic partnership. Modi had met Parmelin in Geneva on June 16.

After Ambulance Halt, Assam Revises CM Convoy Rules

Bikash Singh

Guwahati: A day after an ambulance was stopped owing to the movement of the convoy of Assam chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma in Silchar, the chief minister besides apologising for the incident the state government has issued fresh guidelines for the chief minister's convoy movement.

The guidelines stated the size of the Chief Minister's convoy shall be restricted strictly to the minimum number of vehicles required for security and essential operational purposes. Sarma apologised to a patient and their family after an ambulance was halted to make way for his convoy. Four police officials were suspended for the incident.

Sarma stated in X, "Today in Silchar, an ambulance was halted to make way for my convoy. This is unacceptable, and I apologise to the patient and their family. No Chief Minister's passage should EVER take precedence over a life in need of urgent care. My directions that VIP movement must not disrupt ordinary citizens have been clear. That they were not implemented is deeply troubling. I have asked the concerned officials to take firm action against those responsible and to constitute an inquiry. Let this be a clear warning: the directives on the CM's convoy shall be enforced in letter and spirit. Anyone found violating it will face strict consequences."

Warring Quits as AICC Seeks Truce in Punjab Unit

Our Political Bureau

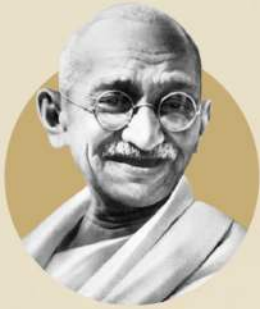
New Delhi: Punjab Pradesh Congress Committee President Amrinder Singh Raja Warring has submitted his resignation to the high command as directed by the latter. Warring made it public by changing his X bio to "former PPCC president" on Friday.

While the AICC had not made any announcement till the time of writing, Warring's exit marked the central leadership giving in to the demand for his removal by many state Congress leaders, including former chief minister CS Channi and senior leader SS Randhawa. This was despite top Congress leaders, including Rahul Gandhi, earlier standing firm with Warring against the rebellion. Among those in the run to be the new PCC president is AICC joint treasurer Vijay Inder Singhla and Channi.

The brewing rebellion not only forced the exit of Warring, a Rahul Gandhi loyalist, but had also earlier forced the exit of then pro-Warring AICC general secretary Bhupesh Baghel, who is known to be close to Priyanka Vadra. It meant the Congress high command trying to buy peace with many state Congress leaders.

Warring's quarrel with Channi and his alleged use of derogatory words against former home minister late Buta Singh added an anti-Dalit charge to his image crisis.





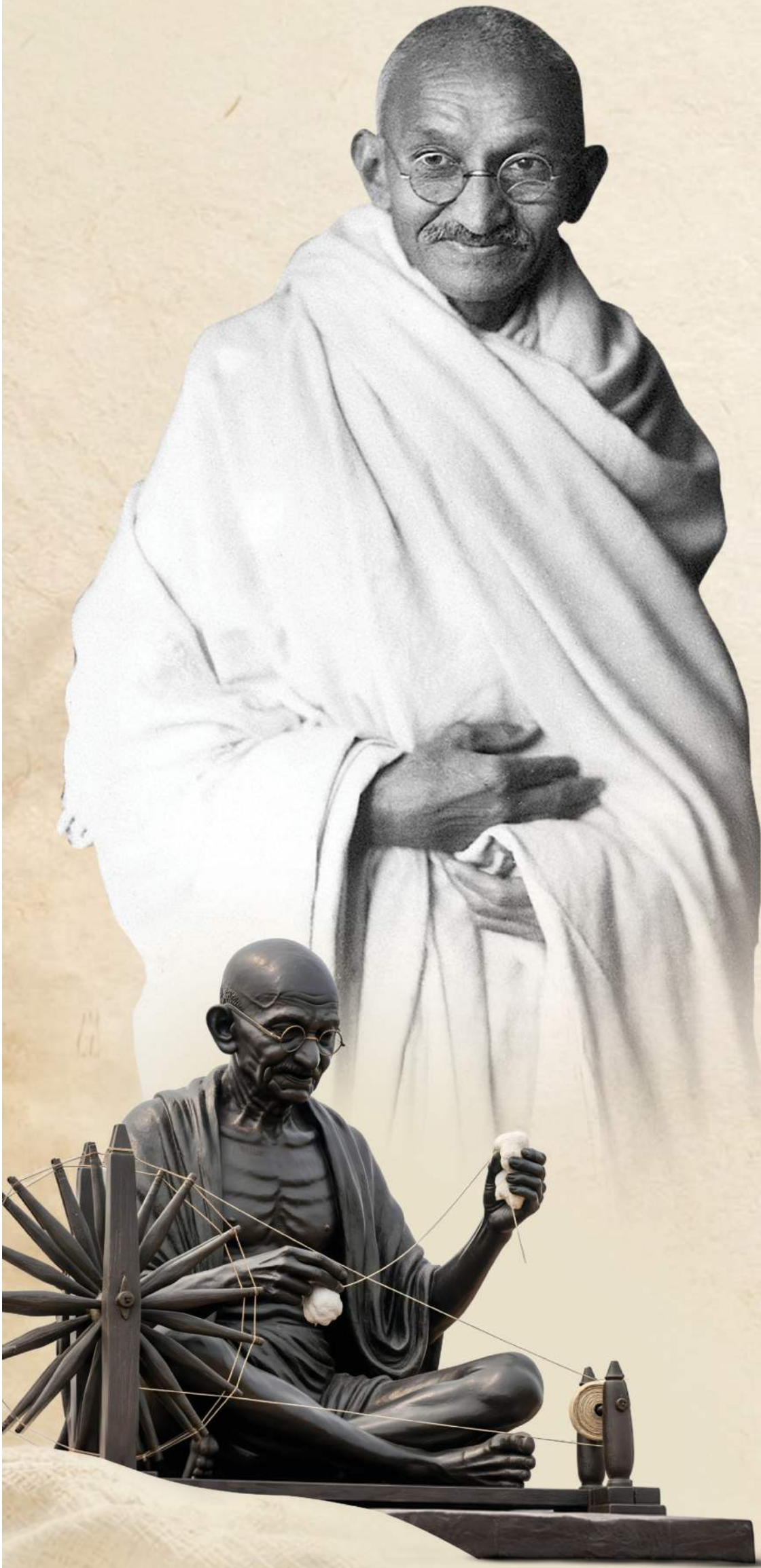
Celebrating the 157th
Birth Anniversary of
Mahatma Gandhi



DEPARTMENT OF INFORMATION AND PUBLIC RELATIONS



Celebrating the 122nd
Birth Anniversary of
Lal Bahadur Shastri



MY LIFE IS MY MESSAGE

Heartfelt wishes to all the
people of the state on the
occasion of Gandhi Jayanti

“
It is my firm conviction that all
good action is bound to bear fruit
in the end ”

— *M.K. Gandhi*

On the birth anniversaries of Father of
the Nation Mahatma Gandhi and former
Prime Minister Lal Bahadur Shastri, whose
lives exemplified the values of **truth,**
non-violence, simplicity, service and
patriotism, we pay our respectful
tributes to these great souls.

**A life devoted to truth.
A legacy that helped shape a nation.**



The Street Feels Global Heat

Local investors have cushioned the fall, somewhat

Bond markets are trying to impose fiscal discipline on governments as borrowing by advanced economies reaches extraordinary levels. Geopolitics isn't helping, with disrupted energy supplies stoking inflation worldwide. Central bankers are raising rates to tame prices, hardening their currencies. All this is grim news for Indian equities, already facing relentless foreign selling. Thursday's sell-off — Sensex fell 571 points and Nifty 199 points, extending an 8-week losing streak — is a sharp reminder of how these global pressures are feeding into Dalal Street. Domestic factors add to the pressure: an erratic monsoon could weigh on rural incomes while keeping food inflation elevated. Household savings have stepped into the breach, pushing more money into equities despite prolonged market decline.

Indian investors are pitted against concerted pressure in international financial markets. A fall in crude below \$100 a barrel would ease some immediate concerns, but a return to the pre-Iran equilibrium looks remote. Nor are bond vigilantes likely to lower their guard. Major economies now spend more servicing their debt than the world invests in AI, by one estimate. A bond-market sell-off has been anticipated for some time; now that it is underway, the squeeze is unlikely to ease soon. Central banks are again seen as being behind the inflation curve, leaving them little choice but to push rates higher, even at the cost of global growth.

Commodity and bond markets will remain adverse for emerging economies such as India. Global equity investment is also increasingly concentrated in AI infrastructure, where India has little significant presence yet. Sustaining growth could become harder in an environment of expensive credit. Indian equities, however, are no longer as richly valued as they were a couple of years ago, with headline multiples moving towards historical averages after a prolonged correction. The correction could have been steeper but for the doughty Indian investor.

MKG & Ahimsa's Realpolitik Value

In an age when diplomacy is property negotiation, ahimsa can sound suspiciously like bringing a yoga mat to a knife fight. This misunderstands both politics and Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi. Gandhi's great innovation was not discovering what humanity had already spotted: that violence is unpleasant. It was recognising that non-violence could be — irony alert — weaponised. Satyagraha was morality engineered into strategy: refuse obedience, accept punishment, expose coercion, and thereby increase the political price of coercing you.

Realpolitik counts money, soldiers, territory, sanctions and bargaining chips — things we're more than familiar with in our 'era of wars'. Ahimsa adds another asset: legitimacy. Governments can overpower demonstrators. But it's harder to make the overpowering look respectable. Violence by protesters changes the subject from their grievance to public order. Disciplined non-violence keeps the phone-cam pointed at the grievance. Gandhi understood that rulers possess guns — or lathis, water cannons, tear gas — but depend upon clerks, taxpayers, lawyers, policemen and, ultimately, consent. The British Empire was formidable. It was also administratively needy. The same holds for today's imperia.

None of this makes ahimsa magical. Non-violent campaigns can fail, be brutally suppressed, or encounter regimes relatively indifferent to reputation. Gandhi's own campaigns produced compromises. But that makes the doctrine more, not less, interesting to realists. Ahimsa is commonly displayed in the museum of politics beside spinning wheels and uplifting quotations. It belongs equally in the armoury. The Mahatma's mischievous achievement was to demonstrate that refusing to hit back need not mean refusing to hit where power hurts.



JUST IN JEST

It's that special day again when benefits of restraint are real-time

Celebrate National Teetotalitarian Day!

As daughters and sons of the nation, we celebrate National Teetotalitarian Day today, a 24-hr experiment in authoritarian sobriety. Today, as Indians, we are free to speak (and wear) whatever we want. But sipping on a double Scotch will be treated as an offence against today's cultural values — and by today's, we mean of this single day. Oh, cheer up, it's less joyless than it sounds. Alcohol is an unusual product whose consumption steadily diminishes the consumer's ability to judge whether further consumption is prudent. By the fourth drink, rational-choice theory has left the building, usually without paying its share of the bill.

Teetotalitarianism restores fiscal discipline at household level. Money otherwise spent on overpriced wine remains available for economically sounder purposes, such as overpriced coffee. There are other savings. No drunken WhatsApp message to boss or colleague requiring a morning clarification. No mysterious credit-card entry that must be investigated. The value of celebrating a secular dry day is its unusually rapid policy transmission. Most governments demand restraint now to reap promised benefits several years away. Teetotalitarianism asks for restraint tonight. By breakfast tomorrow, you shall raise your glass to your very good judgement. So, let's raise a glass to National Teetotalitarian Day. And to tomorrow — it's National No-Hangover Day!

Boards should build a strong leadership pipeline long before the search begins for the next CEO

Find Success in Succession



CEO succession is one of the most important decisions a board makes. Yet, most boards treat it as an event, rather than a process, giving it little weight until triggered by a performance challenge, retirement or resignation. Until then, succession planning rarely gets attention. Most boards and nomination committees will tell you all is well. But when succession becomes real, often suddenly, that confidence can prove fragile. External searches become compressed and reactive. Internal candidates who could have been prepared are not ready. Worse, potential contenders may have left, seeing no path forward, or investment in their development.

Done well, succession is an active, multi-year talent-development system. It forces the right stretch assignments, builds a broad-based pool of leaders, and gives the board a much deeper understanding of the company's top talent. It may even be the best top-talent development system available to a company.

► Early bird The best boards start this process 5-7 yrs before a transition. Early on, the field stays wide — 15-20 people supported through coaching and leadership development, with the board and CEO investing time. Potential often becomes clear only when people are stretched in unfamiliar roles.

The aim is to build a strong leadership pipeline. For many companies, that stronger bench is the real return from doing succession well. In the final 2-3 yrs, the field narrows to 4-5 serious contenders, and the work becomes more focused.

► Make hard choices Boards should ask what kind of CEO will be needed to shape and deliver the future in a company's forward-looking strategy, then translate it into a clear leadership specification.



A specification built around future strategy gives the process a more rigorous brief, and can point to candidates different from the incumbent.

When framing the specification, boards shouldn't let industry experience crowd out capability, potential and strategic fit. Most overestimate the value of 'industry knowledge' and underestimate potential, limiting bolder choices. Boards should also avoid the incumbency trap. If the CEO has been successful, they often look for a successor in the same mould. If the CEO has struggled, they can swing too far: Both are backward-looking.

Recruitment or promotion decisions for senior roles should not be made only to fill today's vacancy. They should also ask whether the appointment creates future CEO optionality: does this role stretch a potential con-

tender, round out a gap, or test someone in a context that will matter later?

Pressure to fill a role can overwhelm the longer-term succession question. Creating small profit centres within the company, and giving top talent a chance to manage an end-to-end business, is one of the better development interventions.

► Involve the whole board Succession can't belong to the chair, CEO or nominations committee alone. The board must own the full arc of the process — defining the specification, engaging with candidates, debating evidence and making the final decision.

Directors need enough exposure to candidates to form views based on evidence, not reputation. Early on, potential leaders present to the board. Later, a smaller group gets deeper exposure and mentoring. When the decision comes, directors need to de-

bate trade-offs honestly, without early preferences or dominant voices shaping the room too soon.

The best chairs orchestrate this carefully: engaging directors individually, holding back their views until others have spoken, and creating conditions for the board to converge. Evidence, discipline and independent challenge keep this sensitive conversation honest.

► Think internal and external If the earlier elements have been done well and there is a strong internal pipeline, boards need not look externally. It risks demotivating and potentially losing strong internal talent. However, looking externally not only expands the choice set but also sharpens the board's judgement about the role, the standard it wants to set, and provides a clearer read on its internal contenders.

If an internal candidate is close to the best external option, the internal candidate should usually be preferred. It sends a strong signal to the organisation, preserves continuity and reduces integration risk.

► Keep the process tight Full-board ownership doesn't mean every director needs to be in every conversation. Confidentiality protects candidates, internal trust and process integrity. The chair's role is important. In promoter-led companies, so is the promoter's. They must avoid signalling preferences, even informally.

► Not just CEO duty There's also a structural problem at the centre of any succession process that boards are often reluctant to name. Many CEOs find it hard to develop their own successors. It can feel threatening, or lead CEOs to over-identify with leaders who resemble their own path. This is why boards must take charge of this process, and not leave it entirely to CEOs.

The real test of CEO succession is not only whether the board chooses the right person, but also if it has built a company with more leaders ready for bigger roles. Boards that understand this stop treating succession as an emergency plan and start treating it as the company's most important talent system, leaving the enterprise stronger no matter who gets the job.

Mariwala is chairman, Marico. Khemka is senior partner, Egon Zehnder

BRICS Building Anti-Dollar Walls?



Stéphanie Heng & Alban de la Soudière

It's not yet a monetary revolution. But it's a real change, perhaps just as important. For decades, the dollar has been the lubricant of world trade. Oil, gas, raw materials, most international trade, forex reserves — almost everywhere, the dollar has established itself as the reference currency. And this trade dominance has had a particularly favourable consequence for the US. The world needs dollars, which have been circulating, some of which comes back to buy US debt.

This system has not disappeared, far from it. But it is being eroded. And BRICS' expansion is a very visible symptom of it. The grouping now has 11 members, plus several partner countries. Their aim is not specifically to create a single currency that would compete with the dollar. More pragmatically, the goal is to re-

duce the need to use dollars when both trading partners can settle directly in their own currencies. And it is in the energy sector that this evolution becomes particularly interesting.

Russia, under Western sanctions, has sharply accelerated its exchanges in national currencies. With China, the rouble and renminbi are now at the heart of trade settlements. As for India, Russian oil has pushed both countries to develop mechanisms of settlement in roubles and rupees, and this in parallel with other currencies.

China, for its part, is methodically pushing the renminbi in its energy and trade exchanges. Not necessarily to replace the dollar, but to create enough alternatives so that the US currency is no longer the necessary transit route, and to limit the impact of sanctions. BRICS and de-dollarisation won't make the dollar disappear. But they are helping to make the world monetary system progressively more multipolar.

Outside BRICS, the euro is already a major invoicing currency for international trade. Most intra-European trade, including in the energy sector, is naturally conducted in euros.

But as a counter-example, oil and gas imports from Norway or Algeria



No, it's not a joke

are not systematically paid in euros, despite privileged links between the EU and these two countries. In any case, it only applies to some of the long-term contracts, which are numerous and often confidential.

On the other hand, the overnight oil price, including the North Sea Brent reference, remains firmly quoted in dollars. Nevertheless, existence of a European currency capable of handling an increasing share of international settlements is, indeed, an alternative to the dollar.

De-dollarisation doesn't mean the imminent end of the dollar, but rather a gradual diversification of global reserves, notably at the expense of US treasury bonds. The real risk for the US is that foreign demand for US debt slows even as financing needs explode.

The Norwegian case is particularly

interesting. On September 1, Norges Bank recommended reducing the share of government bonds in the sovereign wealth fund's benchmark from 70% to 50%. This could reduce dollar bonds exposure by

about \$80 bn. It's not a political decision to 'exit the dollar'. The fund would retain significant exposure to the dollar itself. But it's an interesting signal.

Over time, less foreign demand and more debt mean potentially higher refinancing rates. And a few dozen additional basis points, applied gradually to a colossal debt, can cause a vicious circle of interest costs, deficit, debt, more interest costs, not to mention the serious risks on exchange rates and inflation (both monetary and imported).

The biggest risk, then, is not the dollar's demise but the gradual end of exceptionally cheap US financing, with potentially huge consequences for US finances and, thus, the entire global financial system.

Heng works at European Parliament. De la Soudière was with NATO Communications and Information Agency (NCIA). Views are personal

Mr Prez, Use Your Discretion Wisely



Mohit Saraf

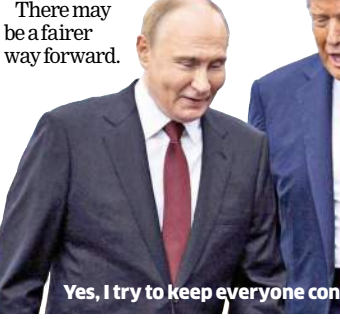
On Wednesday, Narendra Modi called Donald Trump to discuss matters on trade, energy and defence. He also reportedly highlighted India's concerns over Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act 2026. Trump signed the sanctions law on Sept 18, giving himself as president substantial authority to impose tariffs up to 100% on major purchasers of Russian energy. The important aspect of the law is that such an imposition will be on presidential 'discretion'.

For India, the question isn't about how many barrels of Russian oil it buys, but whether countries with profoundly different levels of development, economic capacity and strategic relationships with the US should be treated alike. Say, China and India, profoundly different countries, both of which 'do business' with Russia.

This is where, for India, economics meets strategy. India and the US have spent more than two decades building one of the world's most consequential strategic relationships. Trump and Modi have described the US-

India Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership in terms of mutual trust, shared interests and goodwill. Ambassador Sergio Gor expressed the principle well: 'Real friends can disagree but always resolve their differences in the end.' The Russian oil question provides an opportunity to demonstrate that principle. India's continued purchase of Russian oil should not be mistaken for indifference — either by GoI or India's people — to the suffering caused by Russia's war on Ukraine. But an elected government must also consider the hardship that significantly higher energy costs can impose on its own citizens.

None of this diminishes Washington's legitimate strategic objective of reducing revenues available to Russia to sustain its war in Ukraine. But it raises another important question: who should bear the economic cost of achieving that objective? There may be a fairer way forward.



If Washington wants New Delhi to substantially reduce Russian oil purchases, the US and India could explore an arrangement under which alternative supplies — including US crude — reach India at a landed cost comparable with the Russian oil being displaced. Such a request would, then, become economically much easier for New Delhi to accommodate. If India is being asked to alter its energy sourcing in pursuit of a shared geopolitical objective, the incremental economic cost need not fall disproportionately on the Indian people.

That is the central issue. Energy affordability in India is not simply about protecting corporate margins, or headline GDP. It directly affects the country's ability to move hundreds of millions of people towards economic security.

There is also a strategic relationship at stake. India-US cooperation today encompasses defence, critical technologies, semiconductors, AI, resilient supply chains, counterterrorism and the Indo-Pacific. The two countries are simultaneously seeking deeper trade and investment ties, and more resilient and trusted supply chains. The question for Washing-

ton, therefore, is larger than Russian crude: what combination of pressure, incentives and alternative energy supplies best advances US objectives without imposing disproportionate developmental costs on India, or damaging a strategic relationship built over decades?

A tariff potentially reaching 100% is an extraordinarily powerful instrument. Its consequences would extend far beyond the oil trade. And a strategic relationship is not really tested when interests coincide. Its durability is tested when they diverge.

India and the US will disagree from time to time. They are two large sovereign democracies, each pursuing its own national interests. With the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, Trump wields considerable discretion. Using that discretion should involve looking beyond the immediate question of where India buys a barrel of oil. It should also involve considering India's level of development, economic consequences of today's exceptionally high energy prices, and strategic value of a trusted relationship that both countries have spent decades constructing.

The challenge is to ensure that a disagreement over Russian oil does not obscure the much larger question of where India and the US want their relationship to be 20 yrs from now.

The writer is founder & managing partner, Saraf & Partners



Leadership Masterclass

CHE TAN SAVLA

When a leader mobilises nearly 350 mn people to follow him, there must be something to learn from him. M K Gandhi had five great leadership qualities that propelled his ability to lead our nation into a unified movement.

First, he had a vision of a free, self-reliant nation that could give wings to a people enslaved for centuries. It was a powerful purpose and goal, and every Indian found their calling in it, regardless of ethnic or religious background.

Second, he was, and was widely perceived to be, a man of integrity. His followers could trust his motives and take his words at face value.

Third, he showed empathy and emotional connection by living like some of the most impoverished sections of Indic society. He listened to his opponents as much as he listened to his followers, and that gave him the unique ability to bridge gaps between the two sides.

Fourth, he had a powerful ability to enforce his will on matters he believed in. His fasts unto death to change behaviour of his own followers on more than one occasion were a case in point.

Finally, he was a mastermind at execution and large-scale organisation. He selected a great team of leaders such as Sardar Patel and Nehru, and his satyagraha movements in South Africa, the non-cooperation movement, the Dandi March, and the salt tax agitation were masterful ideas executed on a national scale. Albert Einstein said about Gandhi, 'Generations to come will scarcely believe that such a man ever walked the earth.'



Petting an Animal

There's a tangible rush of peace in running a hand over an animal. A dog offers its head with expectant joy; a cat becomes the resident zamindar with each stroke. Even a horse radiates gentleness beneath your palm.

Part of the pleasure is that nothing needs explaining. Animals don't require anecdotes, opinions or updates. The hand moves; fur or skin moves beneath it; breathing slows. For a few minutes, two creatures agree that this is sufficient.



Friendly interaction with animals has been associated with increases in oxytocin, a hormone involved in social bonding. Studies have also found reductions in cortisol, a marker of stress. Touch itself can engage sensory and nervous-system pathways associated with calm. Heart rate and blood pressure may ease. The body, apparently, understands petting before the mind has finished worrying. But this quiet joy exceeds chemistry. To pet an animal is to communicate without the exhausting apparatus of language. For once, nobody is trying to improve anybody. You are simply touching another living thing, and it is allowing you to stay.

Chat Room

Wake Up, Lazies, And Smell Work

A public holiday on October 2, to mark the birth anniversary of Mohandas Gandhi, is bringing disrepute to the great leader who would never have wanted his countrymen to be lazy and non-productive on the day he was born. A single holiday means loss of thousands of crores to the economy that a developing country like India can ill-afford. Gandhi was the architect of the freedom movement, and India attained independence because our freedom fighters, including Gandhi, worked tirelessly. As a nation, we love to celebrate, mourn and even protest with a holiday, which is unethical in today's context where time is money and every minute must be respected for its worth. The nation must amend its Constitution and remove 'unproductive' holidays like Gandhi Jayanti. Instead, we must pay homage to the 'mahatma' by working extra hours as a mark of respect to the great leader. S N Kabra Mumbai

FOCUS ON MUTUALLY BENEFICIAL INTERIM AGREEMENT

Goyal Meets Greer in Push for Early Trade Pact

Commerce minister holds 'productive discussion' with USTR; highlights weaponisation of food supply chains

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said he had a "productive discussion" with US trade representative Jamieson Greer towards early conclusion of a mutually beneficial interim trade agreement between India and the US.

They met Wednesday on the sidelines of the G20 trade ministers' meeting in Milwaukee, the same day when Prime Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump held a telephone conversation to review the progress in bilateral cooperation across trade, defence, energy, critical technologies and other areas of mutual interest. "Had a productive discussion with USTR Greer towards early



Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal meets USTR Jamieson Greer on the sidelines of G20 trade ministers' meeting in Milwaukee, Wisconsin, on Wednesday - ANI

conclusion of a mutually beneficial interim agreement under the India-US Bilateral Trade Agreement. We also exchanged views on G20 deliberations under US Chairship," Goyal wrote in a social media post. The minister is visiting the US from September 29 to October 5 to attend the G20 trade ministers' meeting and hold deliberations with Greer on the bilateral trade agreement.

Speaking at a session on 'Weaponization of Food through Coercive Trade Action' during the G20 trade ministers' meeting, Goyal highlighted that the shared objective must be to ensure that food remains a source of security, stability and cooperation. "Also, underlined that we must clearly distinguish between the weaponisation of food supply chains and legiti-

mate measures adopted by countries to pursue domestic policy objectives and address food-security needs," Goyal said in another social media post.

India maintains public stockholding, procures from small and marginal farmers and, in the event of a harvest shortfall, adopts temporary and transparent measures to ensure the availability and affordability of food, the minister said. He called for a clear distinction between measures taken to ensure food security and coercive trade actions and reaffirmed India's commitment to a rules-based, fair, non-discriminatory, equitable, transparent, open, inclusive and multi-lateral trading system, with the WTO at its core. "The ministers reached consensus on the outcome document, 'G20 Statement on the

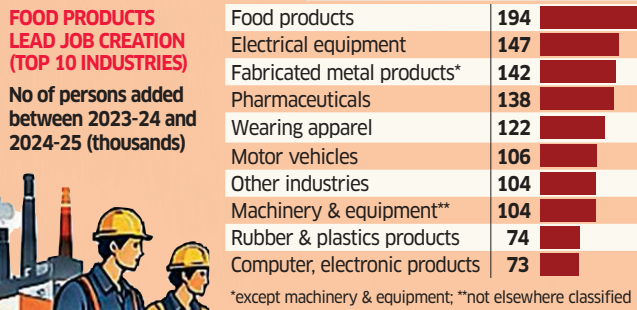
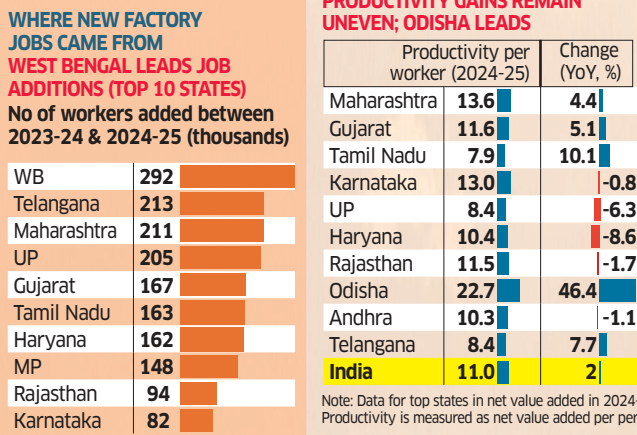
Weaponisation of Food Through Coercive Trade Actions', and expressed their intent to continue cooperation on the subject," the commerce and industry ministry said in a news release.

MEET WITH SEFCOVIC

The minister met European Trade Commissioner Maros Sefcovic on the sidelines of the trade ministers' meeting, wherein they reviewed the progress towards the signing and entry into force of the India-EU free trade agreement and exchanged views on progress under the India-EU Trade and Technology Council, WTO reforms and shared G20 priorities. The two sides concluded the FTA in January this year; almost two decades after launching the initial negotiations in 2007.

Factory Engine Revs Up Jobs and Earnings Rise

India's factory workforce crossed 20 million in 2024-25, led by gains in West Bengal, Telangana, Maharashtra and UP, and sectors such as food products and electrical equipment. Industrial GVA rose 9.6% to ₹26.9 lakh crore, and productivity inched up to ₹11 lakh per worker, though it declined in several key states. Average earnings increased to ₹3.8 lakh. Anoushka Sawhney takes a look.



Sugar Stock Limit Halved to 1,000 Quintals for Traders

Our Bureau

Pune: The government halved the maximum stock of sugar a dealer or trader can hold during a 15-day period to 1,000 quintals, effective October 15.

This is the third revision to the stockholding limit in two months. The latest limit will be effective until the end of November, according to the Ministry of Food and Consumer Affairs.

The stock limit for Kolkata, however, is higher at 2,000 quintals, as the city is the base to source sugar from Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra and Karnataka and supply to the eastern part of the country, including the northeast. The limit is 2,000 quintals for Assam as well, keeping in view the geographical constraints, transportation logistics and consumer interest in the north-eastern region, it said.

India started its new sugar season on October 1 with the central government tightening regulatory measures to ensure sugar prices remain stable during Dussehra and Diwali, when consumption typically increases. The government directed su-

gar mills to ensure that at least 45% of the fortnightly allocated quota is sold and lifted/discharged during the first week of October; from October 1 to 8.



MONTHLY ECONOMIC REVIEW FOR SEPTEMBER

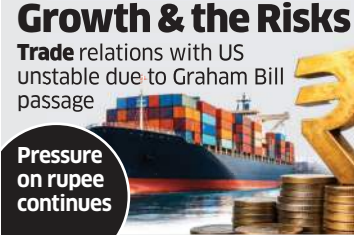
Finmin Pegs Q2 GDP Growth at 7.3%

Cautions that India faces challenges in attracting capital flows because of near-term uncertainties

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The finance ministry has projected a 7.3% increase in gross domestic product (GDP) in the quarter to September quarter, higher than the 6.4% forecast by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI).

It cautioned, though, that India, like other developing nations, faces a stiff challenge in attracting capital flows as near-term uncertainties over US trade relations, crude price surges and the "absence of an India angle" to global artificial intelligence (AI)-related devel-



Growth & the Risks Trade relations with US unstable due to Graham Bill passage. Concerns rise over AI bubble. India faces tough challenge in increasing capital inflows. Must become competition-friendly rather than business-friendly. Pressure on rupee continues.

opments weigh on its investment attractiveness. "Growth momentum has extended into Q2 FY27, though at a more measured pace... Our nowcasting measure, unveiled in the Economic Survey earli-

er this year, anticipates a real GDP growth rate of 7.3% in the fiscal second quarter," the finance ministry said in its

Monthly Economic Review (MER) for September.

However, it warned that India "cannot afford to rest on its post-Covid growth laurels" due to the geopolitical and geo-economic uncertainty that plagues the world. "It has to be earned every quarter. That is the challenge for policymakers," it said. According to the

report, there are indications that net foreign direct investment inflows will surpass last year's figures.

KMF Karnataka Co-Operative Milk Producers' Federation Limited
KMF Complex, Dr M H Marigowda Road, Bangalore-560029
Phone :080- 26096832/910/922 Fax : 080-25536105
E-mail : purchase@kmf.coop

IFT No.: KMF/PIR/CPC/le-Proc./Tender-964/2026 Date: 28.09.2026

TENDER NOTIFICATION (Through-KP Procurement Portal only)

The Karnataka Milk Federation, Bangalore invites tenders from eligible tenderers for supply of Flexi Pack Printed 5 Layered (UHT) Film for Packing Milk (BAMUL, BEMUL, CHIMUL, DKMUL, RBKMUL & TUMUL) and Aluminium Alloy 40 ltrs Capacity can with lid & spare lid. Tender documents may be downloaded from e-Procurement website <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in/>. The tenderers may submit tenders on or before 13.10.2026 up to 03.00 PM

EMD & Other details can be seen in the tender document.

For Karnataka Co-Opp. Milk Federation Ltd.,
Sd/- DIRECTOR (PURCHASE)



Rail Wheel Plant/Bela
(Distt. - Saran) Bihar - 841221

E-Open Tender Notice No.: S/RWPIE/2026-27/17, Dated: 29.09.2026 Principal Chief Materials Manager / Rail Wheel Plant, Bela for and on behalf of the President of India invites online "E-Open Tender", through Indian Railways E-Procurement Website www.ireps.gov.in, for supply of following Stores item at RWP/Bela. The closing time of all tenders is 14:00 hrs. **Tender No.** 02265131.
1. Short Description of item: Supply installation, commissioning and testing of Metallurgical microscope with image analysing system at RWP/Bela. **Quantity:** 01 Nos. **2. Short Description of item:** Proposal of annual maintenance contract for 05 Years. **Quantity:** 05 Nos. **Due Date /Time of closing:** 22.10.2026 at 14:00 Hrs. Website address, on which full tender details can be seen and downloaded from, is www.ireps.gov.in.

For PCMM/RWP/Bela
RWP/CPRO/ADVT/2026-27/68

FORM G
INVITATION FOR EXPRESSION OF INTEREST FOR
COMET GRANITO PRIVATE LIMITED
OPERATING IN BUSINESS OF MANUFACTURING OF CERAMIC VITRIFIED TILES, AT SURVEY NO.118, NATIONAL HIGHWAY NO.8-A, TAL MORBI, NAVA JAMBUDIYA, GUJARAT, 363842 AND AT SURVEY NO. 169 P1 to P6, RATAVIROAD, WANKANER, MORBI, GUJARAT- 363 621.
(Under regulation 36A (1) of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (Insolvency Resolution Process for Corporate Persons) Regulations, 2016)

SL.	RELEVANT PARTICULARS
1.	Name of the corporate debtor along with PAN & CIN/LP No. Comet Granito Private Limited CIN: U26914/GJ2006PTC049091 PAN: AACCC9062H
2.	Address of the registered office Registered Office: Survey No.118, National Highway No.8-A, Tal Morbi, Nava Jambudiyaa, Gujarat, India, 363842
3.	URL of website Not Accessible
4.	Details of place where majority of fixed assets are located Morbi, Gujarat. Further details can be sought from the RP by sending an email on corp.comet@gmail.com
5.	Installed capacity of main products/services The Corporate Debtor operates two manufacturing units engaged in the production of ceramic vitrified tiles, having a combined installed capacity of 852 MT per day, as detailed as below: Unit 1, situated at Survey No. 118P, NH-8A, Nava Jambudiyaa, Morbi, has an installed capacity of 399 MT per day. Unit 2, situated at Survey No. 169 P1 to P6 and adjoining survey numbers at Ratavirada, Wankaner, with installed production capacity of 453 MT per day, spread across two production lines, one with a capacity of approximately 13,500 square meters per day and the other with a capacity of approximately 10,000 square meters per day respectively.
6.	Quantity and value of main products/services sold in last financial year Quantity-3,42,640 Boxes; Value-Rs. 41.29 Crores
7.	Number of employees/workmen Two (2)
8.	Further details including last available financial statements (with schedules) of two years, lists of creditors are available at URL. The details can be sought from the RP by sending an email on corp.comet@gmail.com . The list of creditors is also available on the website of IBBI.
9.	Eligibility for resolution applicants under section 25(2)(h) of the Code is available at URL. The detailed invitation for expression of interest which shall include the eligibility for resolution applicants under section 25(2)(h) of the Code can be sought from the RP by sending an email on corp.comet@gmail.com
10.	Last date for receipt of expression of interest October 17, 2026
11.	Date of issue of provisional list of prospective resolution applicants October 27, 2026
12.	Last date for submission of objections to provisional list November 1, 2026
13.	Date of issue of final list of prospective resolution applicants November 11, 2026
14.	Date of issue of information memorandum, evaluation matrix and request for resolution plans to prospective resolution applicants November 16, 2026
15.	Last date for submission of resolution plans December 16, 2026
16.	Process email id to submit Expression of Interest corp.comet@gmail.com
17.	Details of the corporate debtor's registration status as MSME Details not available with the RP

Anil Kashi Drolia
Resolution Professional of Comet Granito Private Limited
Reg. No: IBBI/UPA-001/IP-P02327/2020-2021/13482
Correspondence address: 5th Floor, Building No. 4, Solitaire Corporate Park, 451-452, Andheri-Kurla Road, Chakola, Andheri East, Mumbai - 400093
Registered Address: 508, Ekta Woods, Raheja Estate, Kulpupwadi, Borivali-East, Near National Park, Mumbai -400066.
Date: October 2, 2026
Place: Mumbai

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Tel No.0161-2456704 & Mob-9646118208 email: srxen-proc-lhd@pstcl.org

Description of Tender
Tender Reference No. 185 /2026-27 (Open Tender)

1 The department of Punjab State Transmission Corporation Limited invites online bids for "Supply & Commissioning of Twenty (20) nos. 15 kV Insulation Testers for 400/220/132 kV Substation under P&M organization in PSTCL"
Closing date and Time: 02.11.2026 11:00 AM
Opening date and Time: 04.11.2026 11:00 AM

Note: It is informed that in case tender process is not completed due to any reason, no corrigendum will be published in newspapers Details regarding corrigendum may be seen on official PSTCL website www.pstcl.org. Terms and conditions may be downloaded from PSTCL's web site <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in>

Sr. Xen./W&A,
O/oCE/P&M PSTCL, Ludhiana

DPR/107b:1078/12/2026-27/15810

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Email: nafhyd@nafed-india.com website: www.nafed-india.com

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State Head
NAFED, Telangana

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SCAN TO REGISTER

Renaissance Solar Plans to Invest ₹5k cr in Karnataka

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Renaissance Solar and Electronic Materials (RSOLEC) has proposed a ₹5,000-crore investment to set up a 5 GW solar ingot and wafer manufacturing facility in Tumakuru near Bengaluru, Karnataka's industries minister MB Patil said on Thursday.

The company, an Indo-US joint venture, has sought 100 acres of land in the Chennai-Bengaluru Industrial Corridor

(CBIC) region in Tumakuru for the proposed facility, Patil said in a statement after meeting RSOLEC chairman and chief executive officer Milind S Kulkarni earlier in the day.

The plant will manufacture solar ingots and wafers, used for making photovoltaic solar cells and panel, and is expected to start operations by the middle of 2028, he said.

TCS to Take Over Best Buy's India GCC

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: India's largest IT services firm, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), will take over US electronics retailer Best Buy's global capability centre in India under a multi-year agreement, the company announced late on Thursday.

The Best Buy India entity will transition to TCS, the firm noted in the stock exchange filing. They did not disclose the deal value, the

agreement's duration or the number of employees who will move to TCS.

TCS plans to develop the centre into a AI-native capability centre, using its Global Value & Innovation Centres framework.

Teams will redesign work processes and develop AI applications for Best Buy, combining the retailer's business knowledge with TCS's technology and engineering capabilities, the filing said.

The company also sees scope to extend the work beyond Best Buy. "By bringing that talent together with TCS' retail expertise, AI, engineering and global execution capabilities, we will create an AI-native capability engine that aligns Best Buy's priorities. This partnership will also create a repeatable value platform that can potentially benefit the broader retail industry," said Krishnan Ramanujam, president of TCS's consumer business group.

Slurrp Farm Eyes Fresh Funds As Old Investors Seek Exit

Reghu Balakrishnan & Ratna Bhushan

Mumbai | New Delhi: Bollywood actress Anushka Sharma-backed snacking and breakfast cereal maker Slurrp Farm is exploring a fresh fundraising as some of its existing backers are looking to exit their holdings amid heightened investor interest and rapid growth in the healthy snacking category, said people aware of the plans. Talks with the potential investors are at

an early stage, and the size and structure of the proposed deal, including the quantum of stake sale, haven't yet been finalised, the people said. "Slurrp Farm is in talks for a large fundraise which may include offloading a significant minority stake, while details around valuation are in process of being discussed," said one of the persons cited above.

Slurrp Farm was valued at ₹27 crore in a Series C5 fundraising round this August.

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BY COMMUNITY

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BY LANGUAGE

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BY COMMUNITY

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IT is for general information that I Renuka Sharana Basavaraj Ballari Mallappa D/o Shivappa Venkatapur and Ex. wife of Sharana Basavaraj Ballari Mallappa, R/o Plot No 12, Shankari Layout, Near Purandara Mantapa, Yalakkishettar Colony, VTC-Dharwad, PO-Dharwad Vidyagiri, Sub District-Hubli, Dist-Dharwad, Karnataka-580004, declare that I got divorce from my Ex. husband vide Court Decree No.-M.C.No.74/2020 dated 15.03.2025. Further, I have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Renuka Shivappa Venkatapur.

IT is known to all that I,Hampamma, daughter of Sharanappa and wife of Prakash Kumbhar, residing at No.201, P S R Nest, Cholanayakana Halli Bangalore-560032, have changed my name from Hampamma to Anupama P Kumbhar vide affidavit dated 30 Sep 2026 before Notary Leela Bengaluru. From now on, I will be known as Anupama P Kumbhar for all purposes.

I, Shiddanagouda M Kaggalagoudar S/o Mahadevagouda R/o Plot No 23, Lingaraj Nagar Road, Adyapak Nagar, Siddeshwar Park, VTC-Hubli, PO-Hubli Eng College, Sub District-Hubli, District-Dharwad, Karnataka - 580031, have changed my minor son's name from Amogh S K Aged 17 years to D N Shanthi Raj forever

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I, Balusupreeth M J residing at Flat No 301 3rd Floor Sohan Residency No 29 1st A Cross 2nd Main 5th Block 3rd Phase BSK 3rd Stage Bengaluru-560085 have changed my name to Supreeth Pinto for all purposes.

I Asha Dileep D/o Anjaprayil Kunhan Balan and W/o Dileep K R/o SY No-658 882 Bs Woodside Park, VTC-Kodathi, PO-Carmelaram, Dist-Bengaluru, Karnataka-560035, have changed my name to Asha Balan

I, Geetha B, Wife of L.Balaji resident of T-1,Shivajites Apt, Thindlu, Bangalore 560097 have changed my Name from Geetha B to Geetha Balaji vide affidavit dated 29-09-2026 at Bangalore

I, Pandare Anjana Shankar W/O, Chidanand Chougule R/o Peta Lain Kunnur, Belagavi 591215 have changed my name to Anjali Chougule for all purposes

I, B. Jyoti W/o 14856250L, Hav, B Asantulu of 1 ATC changed my name from B. Jyoti to Buda Jyoti, for All Purpose.

I, Sushma BS, W/O, 6501320P-Sep/ASH-Varadaraju, R/o, Mahadevapura, Udduru, Mysore, KA, changed name to Sushma B S, for all purpose.

I, 6504754A, Sep, Manoj Kumar of ASC Records (AT) my mother changed name Shri Mati Ram Kali to Ramkali, for all purpose.

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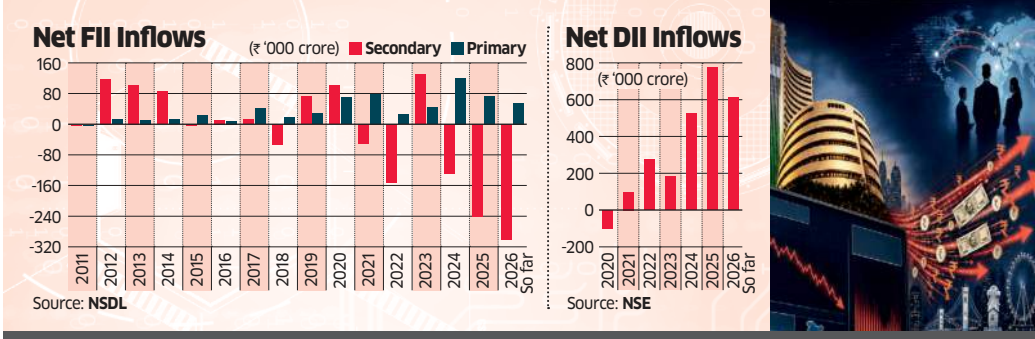
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Record money leaves India in the first nine months of 2026

E for Exit, F for FPIs

Foreign Outflow Tops ₹3 lakh crore



Ravindra Sonavane & Rozebud Gonsalves

Mumbai: Foreign portfolio investors have pulled out more than ₹3 lakh crore from Indian equities in the first nine months of 2026, surpassing all previous annual outflow records with three months still left in the year. This is the first time outflows from the secondary market have crossed the ₹3 lakh crore mark, underscoring the extent of the risk-off sentiment towards India among overseas investors.

FPIs have sold more than ₹3.05 lakh crore so far in 2026, according to NSDL data, compared with withdrawals of ₹2.4 lakh crore in 2025 and ₹1.21 lakh crore in 2024. Including selling in government bonds under the Fully Accessible Route (FAR), FPIs have pulled out a total of close to ₹3.58 lakh crore from both asset classes.

Rising US bond yields, a stronger dollar and shifting expectations around global interest rates have reduced the relative attractiveness of emerging market equities, said Gautam Duggad, MD & head of sales, Institutional Equities at Motilal Oswal Financial Services.

"Elevated crude oil prices could also weigh on India's import bill and corporate margins, adding to concerns over earnings," he said. "We do not expect a meaningful turnaround in FPI flows until there is greater clarity or respite on global yields, interest rates, the US dollar, and cooling of crude oil prices." Their selling has kept the stock market under pressure in 2026, with the Sensex and Nifty down nearly 15.3%

and 14%, respectively, in local currency terms. In dollar terms, both benchmarks have fallen more than 20%.

Out of the nine months, they have been sellers in six, as a boom in AI-centric markets like Taiwan and South Korea prompted many investors to reallocate money there. In July and August, FPIs recorded combined inflows of ₹46,180 crore when the upmove in both these markets fizzled out, but they turned sellers again in September selling around ₹33,000 crore amid the simmering West Asia conflict, a spike in US bond yields, a weakening rupee and a revival in appetite for South Korea and Taiwan.

In government bonds, flows surged in June after the government announced measures to attract foreign capital and on expectations that Bloomberg would include Indian bonds in its flagship Global Aggregate Index. With Bloomberg deferring the inclusion, inflows started to taper from mid-July, and they turned sellers subsequently. Cumulative inflows under the FAR in June and July stood at ₹49,355 crore, while there were outflows of ₹11,439 crore in August and September, CCIL data showed.

Shankar Sharma, founder of Gquant and First Global, said the mood among a few FPIs he had recently met was "extremely negative" on India overall, with investors showing interest mainly in select smaller companies. "They will continue selling. That's going to be the pattern. So they will largely keep exiting large caps, and selectively buy small and mid-cap stocks," he said.

OIL'S RIPPLE EFFECT

US Yield Hits the Highest Since 2002 at 5.34%

Bloomberg

The US benchmark yield touched its highest level since 2002, the latest milestone in a monthslong selloff in global sovereign debt.

The yield on the 10-year Treasury note briefly rose above its 2007 peak to trade at 5.34% on Thursday. Earlier this week, the rate on 30-year US bonds also hit a 24-year high.

Government debt has been flailing around the world as elevated oil prices — tied to the war in the Middle East — ripple through the global economy, pushing investors to bet central banks will further raise interest rates. Massive government borrowing and strong investment in artificial-intelligence infrastructure is adding to the demand for capital, pushing up borrowing costs.

Global government bonds just posted their worst quarter since 2024, according to a Bloomberg index.

An Easy Colleague, Sharp Boss...Bagchi has Made It Count

Saloni Shukla & Shilpy Sinha

Mumbai: For 34 years, the ICICI Group logo headlined Anup Bagchi's business card. That will change in a month as HDFC Bank welcomes the ICICI veteran to its corner office.

Bagchi has run the ICICI securities arm, led retail and wholesale banking, and its life insurer. The central bank has approved Bagchi's appointment for three years, and he succeeds Sashidhar Jagdishan, whose term ends October 26.

Former colleagues describe Bagchi as a sharp executive with an informal manner. He likes cold coffee with ice and finishes a book a week, often on management. He recommends books he enjoys to colleagues, sometimes joking that they have seven days to finish them.

"He would call and ask, 'Are you busy?'" recalled a banking official who worked with him. Say no and he might find you work; say yes and he could tease you about being too busy for a director. A good idea could elicit another joke: "You're talking sense. Now you'll have to buy me a coffee."

That ease with colleagues stands out to people who have worked with him. "In my experience, people with very high IQ often have low EQ. He is an exception," said one official, who asked not to be named.

Bagchi took charge of retail banking at ICICI Bank on November 1, 2016. Demonetisation was announced a week later, sending banks into an operational scramble. "He handled the situation so smoothly that we would say among ourselves: it didn't even feel as though a new boss had arrived," a former colleague said.

A chemical engineering graduate from IIT Kanpur's 1990 batch,



Bagchi also has a management degree from IIM Bangalore. He joined ICICI in 1992 and worked across treasury, corporate banking and retail financial services. He was an executive director from 2017 to 2023, overseeing retail, business and rural banking before moving to wholesale banking.

One official called ICICI a "CEO factory" for the leaders it has supplied to other financial institutions.

ICICI Prudential Life, which Bagchi has led since June 2023, had already begun reducing its dependence on parent bank-ICICI Bank, but he continued to deepen that diversification by expanding other distribution channels and adding more bancassurance partners.

ICICI Bank's contribution, which was once more than 40% of the business, fell to around low double digits a couple of years back. Meanwhile, ICICI Prudential has expanded agency, direct, group and partnership channels and added more bank partners.

People who have worked with Bagchi say once a strategy is settled, he gives existing teams room to deliver it.

Saha has a Way of Connecting the Dots, and Numbers

Saloni Shukla

Mumbai: Kotak Mahindra Bank's next chief executive is an early starter who prefers short meetings, readily switches to Hindi and likes to know what is happening on the ground. Former colleagues say Anup Kumar Saha's unassuming manner is matched by a sharp head for numbers and a particular strength in turning strategy into execution.

The transition from the urbane, internationally experienced Ashok Vaswani to the grounded, straightforward Saha will bring a different personal style to Kotak's leadership. The 56-year-old will take over as managing director and chief executive on January 1, 2027, for a three-year term.

People who have reported to Saha rate him highly as a business operator. His strength, they say, is the effort he puts into understanding an assignment, the depth of his questions and his ability to connect the numbers with what is happening in the business.

"Whatever you put him in charge of, he will go deep. He will take the effort to know what is happening on the ground," said an official who has worked with him.

Another official described him as comfortable with his roots and quick to switch to Hindi. Colleagues recall an executive who arrives early at the office, has little appetite for lengthy meetings and wants a clear understanding of the matter at hand. His attention to detail, they say, makes it difficult to get a superficial explanation past him.

Since joining Kotak in January, Saha has also made an effort to get to know junior members of his team, according to people familiar with his working style. The hands-on approach is consistent with the way former colleagues describe him: business-focused, direct and willing to invest time in understanding operations.



gues describe him: business-focused, direct and willing to invest time in understanding operations.

His career began far from banking. A metallurgy graduate from IIT Kharagpur's 1991 batch, Saha started as a production engineer at Bharat Heavy Electricals. He completed his postgraduate management qualification at IIM Lucknow in 1997, worked at consumer durables company Blow Plast and subsequently moved into financial services, with roles at SBI Cards and GE Capital.

He spent 14 years at ICICI Bank, where his responsibilities included retail secured lending, credit cards, collections and business intelligence, before joining Bajaj Finance in 2017. At the non-bank lender, he held successive leadership roles across consumer finance and other businesses, rising to managing director in April 2025. He resigned in July that year, citing personal reasons.

After a gap of 6 months, he surprised the market when Kotak announced his appointment as wholetime director on January 12 this year. People who know him say he took a spiritual break in the interval between leaving Bajaj Finance and joining Kotak.

VARANI SAHU

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MSCI India	1457	-1.42
MSCI EM	4757	0.30
MSCI BRIC	704	-0.46
MSCI World	23612	-0.17
Japan[Nikkei]	68957	3.30
S.Korea[Kospi]	6971	1.95
Singapore[STI]	5668	-0.14

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Absolute Change

GOLD FUTURES Premium/Discount \$/(15.31)

Comex US (\$/Oz)

MCX India (₹/10Gm)

OPEN 4190.10 149643.00

LAST* 4207.60 150337.00

Prev chg (%) 0.50 2.89

FOREX RATE (₹- \$ Exchange Rate)

OPEN 95.96 LAST* 96.32

*At 6 pm IST

Source: Bloomberg, MCX, ET Data

Market on Twitter@ETMarkets

At 96.31, Rupee Falls the Most in Over 2 Months

KOLKATA The rupee dived the most in more than two months on a day India's prime equity gauges posted their longest losing run in a quarter century, falling half a percentage point to 96.3150 against the dollar.

Rising US bond yields dented emerging market currencies, evident in the sharp climb in the dollar index to 101.9.

The rupee closed the previous session at 95.83 a dollar. Its lowest close so far is 96.96 to a dollar, on May 20. It breached the psychological 96-level twice in three days. — Our Bureau

PRIVATE PLAYERS HAVE EDGE

Loan rates, margins to go up for banks; rising bond yields may be a dampener

Rate Hike to Help Banks Flush with FCNR Flows Boost FY27 Profitability

Joel Rebello

Mumbai: A likely rise in benchmark interest rates by the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) next week could provide banks with scope to increase interest rates. This, together with easier liquidity due to the extraordinary inflow of foreign currency non-resident (bank) (FCNRR) deposits, will help boost banks' profitability for the rest of the financial year, analysts said.

"The rate hike would directly lead to an increase in external benchmark-linked lending rate for banks," said Asutosh Mishra, head of research at Ashika Stock Broking. "The FCNR(B) scheme has now also taken care of the deposit problem because banks were struggling to keep pace with credit growth. All in all this is a positive for banks in the medium term with benefits accruing for at least six months."

Expectations are that RBI will hike its benchmark repo rate by 25 basis points amid rising global rates and higher inflation. This will be the first rate hike since February 2023 and could automatically increase interest rates linked to the repo rate.

HUGE CUSHION

Macquarie expects 75 bps of rate hikes in the next 9 to 12 months, which will support further margin expansion

Strong loan growth of more than 19% means banks have enough avenues to deploy the \$133 billion (₹12,700 crore) raised through the FCNR(B) window.

Macquarie Research analysts Suresh Ganapathy and Dev Shah expect banks to deliver 18% earnings per share (EPS) growth, driven by a 15-basis-point rise in margins in the fiscal year ending March 2028. One basis point is 0.01 percentage point. Macquarie has upgraded Kotak Mahindra Bank and Bank of Baroda (BoB) to outperform from neutral.

"Private banks should deliver strong EPS growth in the next two years as margins improve and operating expenses and credit costs fall," the analysts said. "The macroeconomic backdrop remains supportive; post-FCNR mobilisation has eased liquidity constraints, loan demand is robust and broad-based, asset quality remains healthy, and rate increases appear imminent."

Cashing It On

FCNR (B) inflow will help bank tide over liquidity challenges

Macquarie expects banks to deliver 18% EPS growth driven by a 15 bps rise in margins in FY28

Banks will be helped by automatic increase in repo-linked lending rates to retail, MSMEs

Only risk for banks is if there is not enough loan demand from high yielding customers

Macquarie expects 75 basis points of rate hikes in the next nine to 12 months, which will support further margin expansion.

Macquarie expects private sector banks to benefit more, with 45% to 60% of their loan book linked to the repo rate or external benchmark rate, which means as rates go up, margins will go up. The brokerage has mentioned large lenders like ICICI Bank and State Bank of India as top picks, besides City Union, Kotak and BoB.

However, a sharp rise in benchmark bond yields could pressure banking revenues especially in the second quarter ended September 2026. The benchmark 10-year bond yield has risen to a two and a half year high of 7.21% from around 6.75% at the end of June.

Analysts said with asset quality remaining fairly stable and credit growth strong, the only risk for banks is if they do not get sufficient higher-yielding loans to lend to.

"Even public sector banks will benefit because increasingly all retail and MSME loans are linked to the repo rate. All these loans will be repriced instantly. The only risk is some of the banks, which have garnered a huge amount of deposits, may need to lend to companies at a lower yield, which will not be the most efficient way to lend margin-wise," said Yuvraj Choudhary, research analyst at Anand Rath Securities.

ICICI with \$17.88 billion and HSBC with \$14.5 billion are the top two banks to garner FCNR(B) deposits. A supportive macroeconomic backdrop and robust loan demand should help banks capitalise on easier liquidity following FCNR mobilisation.

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SCAN TO REGISTER

THROUGH DRTS, SARFAESI

ARCs Seek Govt Help to Speed Up Recovery

Shilpy Sinha

Mumbai: Asset reconstruction companies have sought government intervention to speed up debt recovery through the Debt Recovery Tribunals (DRTs) and the Sarfaesi mechanism, and proposed that interim stays be allowed to lapse automatically after two months unless specifically extended by the tribunal.

The Association of ARCs in India also urged the government to advise DRTs to avoid staying recovery proceedings without hearing both sides, ensure prior notice to secured creditors and impose appropriate pre-deposit conditions before hearing an appeal.

It sought filling of vacancies in DRTs within 15 days of them arising and the greater use of electronic services in litigation. It proposed allowing DRTs to rely on authenticated records maintained with National E-Governance Services Ltd as evidence of debt and default, besides penalties for frivolous litigation.

The push comes as DRT and the Sarfaesi mechanisms helped banks recover ₹2.30 lakh crore during 2021-25, compared with ₹2.28 lakh crore recovered through the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code during the same period, according to data compiled by the association.

The Sarfaesi Act empowers banks and financial institutions to take possession and auction collateral properties without judicial intervention to recover bad loans.

Association of ARCs in India chief executive Hari Hara Mishra said the 2002 Act created an enabling environment for banks to repossess charged assets. "Often it is viewed narrowly as a recovery tool only, but it is much more than that. It envisaged a set of dedicated specialised workout units called ARCs, created an instrument called security receipts to facilitate securitisation of stressed assets, again an innovation. Later on, it created a framework for CERSAI, a database for all mortgaged property across all states," he said. "At 25, Sarfaesi has its demographic dividend, and given the right direction can contribute much more to Viksit Bharat."

A MF-LIKE MODEL Smaller players want higher initial EoM limits that decline as they grow

Insurers May Seek Tiered Expense Structure as Against Uniform Cap

Shilpy Sinha

Mumbai: The insurance industry is considering seeking a tiered expense structure, modelled on the mutual fund industry, as an alternative to the uniform expense limits proposed by the sector regulator, people familiar with the discussions said.

Under the proposal being discussed, smaller insurers want to be allowed a higher EoM (expenses of management) limit on their initial premium base, with the permitted expense ratio declining progressively as the insurer grows. The idea is to give new and smaller players greater room to invest in distribution, technology and products while preventing higher expenses from continuing indefinitely as the business scales, they said.

For instance, some midsize companies are discussing a model that would allow an insurer to incur a higher percentage of expenses on its first tranche of premium and progressively lower the limit as premium crosses specified thresholds.

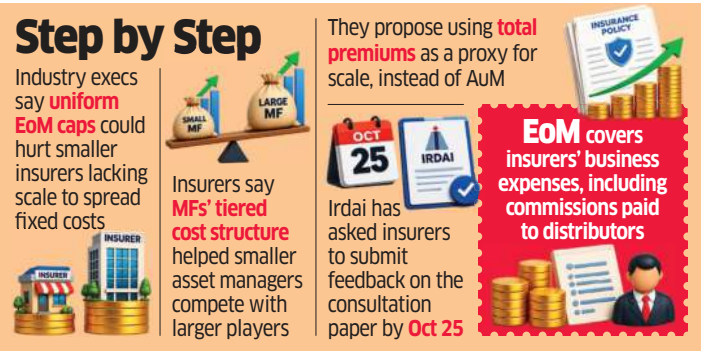
A redevelopment-driven pipeline, strong luxury launch roster and net-cash balance sheet could help realty co sustain the momentum

A Well-Heeled Sri Lotus Has More to Build and Rebuild on

Snehal Mergu

ET Intelligence Group: Shares of Sri Lotus Developers & Realty have surged 29% over the past month, significantly outperforming a weak market, with the BSE Realty index and the benchmark BSE Sensex losing over 6%. The stock hit a 52-week high of ₹233 on Thursday before closing at ₹227.6. Upcoming luxury project launches and redevelopment opportunities are expected to fuel pre-sales, collections and earnings over the next few years. The developer launched two projects towards the end of June, with Lotus Trident already generating around ₹150 crore in pre-sales within a month of launch. Backed by four planned launches with a combined gross development value (GDV) of ₹3,500-4,000 crore, the company has guided for FY27 pre-sales of ₹1,800-2,000 crore, up sharply from ₹1,157 crore in FY26, while maintaining an EBITDA margin outlook of 35-40%, broadly in line with the 36.5% reported in FY26.

The company's ongoing and upcoming pipeline comprises 22 projects, 17 residential and 5 commercial, with an aggregate GDV of around ₹17,500 to 18,000 crore. With 17 redevelopment projects in its pipeline, the company is leveraging opportunities in Mumbai's premium micro-markets, where fresh land supply is



Insurers say MFs' tiered cost structure helped smaller asset managers compete with larger players

They propose using total premiums as a proxy for scale, instead of AUM

IRDAI has asked insurers to submit feedback on the consultation paper by Oct 25

EoM covers insurers' business expenses, including commissions paid to distributors

Insurers started these discussions after the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India proposed to limit the EoM ratio, or the share of premiums that insurers can spend on running the business, including for paying commissions. Under the regulator's proposal, life insurers need to bring their EoM to

15% of gross direct premium within two years and 12.5% in five years. Insurers that were already below the proposed benchmark would eventually have to bring their EoM down to 10%. General insurers need to bring it within 25% in two years and 20% in five years.

Industry executives argue that a uniform EoM ceiling could disproportionately affect smaller or newer insurers that do not have the scale of established players to spread

On the Rise

Quarterly financials of Sri Lotus Developers and Realty (₹ crore)

	Jun'26	Jun'25	YoY chg (%)
Revenue from operations	132.3	61.3	115.9
EBITDA	48.0	29.0	63.0
EBITDA margin (%)	36.4	48.0	-1160 bps
Net Profit	45.7	25.8	77.3

EBITDA: Earnings before interest, tax, depreciation & amortisation.
Bps: Basis points (100 bps = 1% point) Source: Company data, ETIG

limited. Motilal Oswal Financial Services (MOFSL) estimates these projects to offer total pre-sales potential of ₹18,000-19,000 crore and expects pre-sales to grow at 56% annually over FY26-28.

Another medium-term growth catalyst is the company's mixed-use development in GIFT City, where the process to enable commercial, retail and residential development is underway, with key approvals expected by the end of FY27 and construction likely to commence thereafter. The recently secured ₹1,600-crore Juhu commercial redevelopment project provides an additional growth avenue for Sri Lotus, with construction expected to commence after receiving approvals and the project slated for completion over three-four years.

Collections will be an important earnings and cash-flow driver as

projects move into advanced phases of construction. The June quarter collections more than doubled year-on-year to ₹150 crore. The company expects full-year collections of around ₹1,000 crore. It expects billing to accelerate as projects such as Arcadia, Varun and Amalfi move towards higher completion levels. MOFSL expects collections to rise annually by 93% over FY26-28 to ₹1,410 crore.

With a redevelopment-driven pipeline, a strong roster of upcoming luxury launches and a net-cash balance sheet, Sri Lotus is well positioned for sustained medium-term growth. Key monitorables include the timely receipt of approvals, execution of launched projects, sales traction in new micro-markets, and the conversion of bookings into collections and cash flows.

ad technology, distribution and other fixed costs.

According to them, regulations allowing a tiered cost structure in the mutual fund industry helped smaller asset managers to compete with the larger ones. Under the tiered expense structure for mutual funds, the permitted expense ratio decreases as the scheme's assets grow.

The insurance industry is proposing that the total premium be used as a proxy for scale rather than assets under management.

This structure could allow smaller insurers to build scale without immediately being forced to operate at the same cost ratio as much larger players. "This could encourage competition and prevent the market from becoming concentrated among a few large insurers," one executive said.

Insurers are discussing this as part of the consultation process. The regulator has asked insurers to submit feedback by October 25. The exact premium thresholds and EoM will be finalised after taking industry feedback.

Moneyview Closes 67% Above IPO Price, Early Backers Gain

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Digital lender Moneyview's shares closed 67% above their initial public offering price on the listing day Thursday, sharply increasing the paper value of the residual holdings of early investors Ribbit Capital, Accel and Tiger Global, which partially monetised their stakes through the IPO.

The stock listed at ₹55 on the National Stock Exchange, a 61.8% premium to its issue price of ₹34, and ended the day's trading at ₹86.75.

Micky Malka's Ribbit Capital realised about ₹39 crore by selling shares in the IPO's offer for sale (OFS) portion at ₹34 apiece. Its remaining holding was worth about ₹26 crore at Thursday's close. Including the IPO proceeds, the overall value of its investment is now about 19.2 times the acquisition cost. At the IPO price, the gain was 11.8-fold.

Accel realised about ₹83 crore through OFS. Its residual stake, which was worth about ₹1,063 crore at the IPO price, was valued at around ₹1,775 crore at Thursday's close. Including the shares sold in the IPO, its investment is now worth about 9.1 times its acquisition cost of around ₹205 crore, compared with 5.6 times at the issue price.

Tiger Global realised about ₹52 crore through the OFS, while its remaining stake was worth about ₹1,117 crore at the closing price. That takes the combined value of its investment to about 5.5 times its acquisition cost, against 3.4 times at the IPO price.

investors have become more choosy about the winners and losers from the AI revolution and rising rates have put pressure on growth stocks. Excluding deals raising more than \$10 billion, US IPOs this year have fallen 4% on a weighted average basis, the data show.

Listings for SK Hynix, Bending Spoons SpA, Csquare and Jersey Mike's Subs each raised more than \$1 billion in the third quarter. Of the four, Csquare and Jersey Mike's are now trading 25% or more below their respective IPO prices.

With \$162.6 billion raised this year, all eyes are on a potential listing for Anthropic raising as much as SpaceX or more. That would propel the total volume well past the \$195.2 billion record set in 2021.

Tech Picks	AMOL ATHAWALE, VP-Technical Research	Kotak Securities
BLUESTARCO		BUY TARGET ₹1,620
Rounding bottom formation suggests the stock is gaining traction for a fresh up move.		
LAST CLOSE	₹1,554	STOP LOSS ₹1,520
ZYDUSLIFE		BUY TARGET ₹1,180
The stock is near multiple support zones, with the structure suggesting a fresh near-term up move.		
LAST CLOSE	₹1,136	STOP LOSS ₹1,110
JUBLFOOD		BUY TARGET ₹500
The stock has reversed from its key retracement zone, indicating the up move may persist.		
LAST CLOSE	₹482	STOP LOSS ₹470
F&O Strategy	SAHAJ AGRAWAL, VP Derivatives Research	
NSEFUT ICICIPRULI (SEPTEMBER)		BUY TARGET ₹520
The stock has staged a sharp bullish rebound, indicating likely near-term upward momentum.		
LAST CLOSE	₹494.1	STOP LOSS ₹477
NSEFUT APOLLOHOSP (SEPTEMBER)		BUY TARGET ₹9,290
Stock is maintaining its uptrend continuation pattern, indicating likely continuation of the positive trend.		
LAST CLOSE	₹8,828	STOP LOSS ₹8,520

Vast Experience

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The ADR (American Depository Receipts) of HDFC Bank rose 5.5% during early trades following the announcement of a new chief.

The two incoming CEOs have more in common than their first name. Both are IIT alumni and former ICICI Bank executives, with extensive experience across banking and financial services.

Bagchi spent 34 years with ICI-Cl after joining the organisation in 1992, when it was a development finance institution.

He rose through the ranks, working across retail, corporate and investment banking, treasury and other financial services businesses.

Saha worked at ICICI Bank for 14 years, between May 2003 and June 2017, before moving to Bajaj Finance. He has held senior roles across retail secured assets, business intelligence, retail and rural collections, credit

cards and retail structured finance.

The decisions by Jagdishan and Vaswani not to seek fresh terms had opened up the top positions at the two banks and fuelled speculation over their successors. HDFC Bank had recommended deputy managing director Kaizad Bharucha as its first preference, ahead of Bagchi, who was the external candidate.

However, Bharucha has been a whole-time director since June 2014 and would reach the central bank's 15-year ceiling on continuous tenure as a whole-time director, managing director or CEO in June 2029.

Kotak Mahindra Bank had recommended Paritosh Kashyap, its whole-time director and head of wholesale banking, for the top position.

HDFC Bank has a market capitalisation of ₹11.09 lakh crore and total deposits of ₹31.70 lakh crore at the end of June 2026.

\$2.3B CAPEX PLANNED; TN SMELTER RESTART ON CARDS

Vedanta Copper Targets 1 m-Tonne Output by '30

Nikita Periwai

Mumbai: Vedanta Copper plans to spend around \$2.3 billion over three to four years to help expand output beyond 1 million tonnes by the end of the decade, a top executive told ET. This includes a possible restart of its smelter on the Tamil Nadu coast in India, which has been shut for more than eight years, the executive said.

Vedanta Copper is currently a part of Vedanta, which also houses its zinc-lead and silver business. Other group companies have operations across aluminium, zinc, lead, silver, oil and gas, power, iron and steel.

"We are going to produce 500,000 tonnes of copper in India, and another 500,000 tonnes in Saudi Arabia," Puneet Khurana, chief executive officer, Vedanta Copper, told ET. "We are already producing 100,000 tonnes in Fujairah in the UAE."

Around \$2 billion of the company's planned capital expenditure will be used for integrated operations in Saudi Arabia – where it is planning a rod mill, a smelter and mining.

"The rod mill, on which we spent \$33 million, is on the verge of commissioning," Khurana said. "We

have a mine in Jabal Sayid (in Saudi Arabia), which is very rich in copper, gold and zinc, and we are also working on that," he said. For the copper smelter in the region, the company is in advanced discussions with the government, and is likely to take a call in the current quarter itself, Khurana said.

In India, it had an output of 170,000 tonnes of copper cathodes from its plant in Silvassa in fiscal 2026. "As of now, we are producing more than 245,000 tonnes (annually) in Silvassa, which is at 95% capacity. We are also working to start the Tuticorin smelter," he said.

The company's 400,000-tonne smelter at Tuticorin in Tamil Nadu, which was operational for over two decades, was ordered shut by the government in 2018 on account of environmental concerns. "Once the Tuticorin asset is back, it will contribute 250,000 tonnes. A green copper proposal is already in court, and we are expecting a decision in three months' time," Khurana said.

Ripple Effects

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Tata Trusts, of which Noel Tata is the chairman, did not respond to ET's queries.

They also questioned whether a shareholder should direct the Tata Sons board to approve a restructuring that falls within the board's responsibilities.

"A shareholder may express its considered wishes or propose a course of action to a company, but decision-making on that proposal is a matter entrusted to the company's board," they said.

The restructuring involves the merger of two operating companies, regulatory approvals and the surrender of Tata Sons' certificate of registration, with consequences for Tata Sons, group companies, employees and regulators, they said.

The trustees said the proposal also needed to be considered against the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) September 11 response to Tata Sons' application to

surrender its registration. The RBI response directed Tata Sons to comply with norms applicable to an NBFC-Upper Layer, the letter said.

Decisions taken by the trusts in 2025 had been made before the

RBI's latest response and, therefore, should not be seen to determine options now available to Tata Sons, they said.

"This is an issue which the Trusts had fought during RNT's time,"

the trustees said, referring to Ratan Naval Tata. They questioned whether current actions could endanger the position of the trusts and their underlying asset value.

It sought collective deliberation by SDTT trustees. "SDTT's decisions derive their legitimacy from collective deliberation and proper governance process," their letter said.

Waiting for Probe Report

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Full-body scanners have already been deployed on a trial basis at airports in Delhi, Bengaluru, Hyderabad and Kochi.

Pilot testing began earlier this year with BCAS pushing for a wider rollout by next year.

Unlike conventional metal detectors, full-body scanners, as the name suggests, are designed to detect objects concealed within a person's body.

Even non-metallic items can be detected by such machines.

Meanwhile, Israeli prime minister Benjamin Netanyahu said the cockpit alertation onboard the Flydubai flight had a terror angle, adding that the copilot tried to crash the aircraft after stabbing the captain.

Machchhar managed to click open the cockpit door, which allowed passengers to go inside and overpower the co-pilot.

A second set of pilots travelling on the aircraft then helped secure the cockpit and land the plane in Saudi Arabia.

The aircraft was carrying 174 passengers, most of them Israelis.

During the scuffle inside the cockpit, the aircraft went into a rapid descent, losing nearly 14,000 feet in less than 30 seconds, according to flight-tracking data. Secretary Sinha said the incident is being investigated by various agencies.

"We will act as per the outcome of the probe," he said. "After the preliminary report from Flydubai, India will also act to further tighten the security aspect."

Higher Bar for Entry-level Talent

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On hiring, Accenture CEO Julie Sweet told analysts, "...very importantly, we still expect to hire more entry level, which is because we're very focused on really changing sort of what our entry level workers do, what our reinventors do, and then and so that we expect to also continue."

Experts say there is a higher bar for entry-level talent now and that firms are increasingly looking for specialised capabilities such as AI, cloud, data and cybersecurity to drive revenue visibility, meet client demands and deployment readiness with limited ramp-up time.

"At the same time, this does not mean opportunities for freshers have disappeared," said Kapil Joshi, chief executive at Quess IT Staffing. "Rather, hiring is becoming more selective, with greater emphasis

on job-ready skills, hands-on experience and the ability to work with emerging technologies. The market has moved from large-scale, broad-based hiring to more targeted hiring for skills that can contribute quickly to business outcomes."

Sanketh Chengappa, director and business head of professional staffing at Adecco India said the hiring outlook is positive but "the market is not moving back to the volume hiring model of earlier years until about a year back."

"That model has changed now," he said.

Chengappa pointed out that employers are approving roles much more selectively, linking hiring to revenue visibility.

Investors continued to dump Indian equities, said Sunny Agrawal, deputy vice president - Fundamental Research at SBI Securities. Investors are also perturbed by elevated crude oil prices and the resultant decline in the rupee against the dollar, said Ankur Punj, managing director, Equirus Wealth.

'CAPITAL FLIGHT'

In September, overseas funds net sold stock worth ₹44,013 crore. In August, they sold worth ₹7,532 crore. In March,

lity, client demands, product activity and deployment readiness.

According to Nasscom, the divergence in fresher hiring is emerging as an early indicator of demand optimism with those accelerating intake appearing to be more confident in their order books.

"Hiring also showed early signs of recovery, with headcount and fresher additions rebounding, even as attrition rose for a second consecutive quarter," Nasscom said in its report.

Quess data also showed the shift from entry to mid-level hiring.

The share of entry-level IT hiring declined from 20% in 2024 to 15% in 2025, while hiring for mid-level staff with 4-10 years of experience rose from 50% to 65%, a 15 percentage point rise, making this cohort the clear majority of IT hiring demand.

during the peak of the Iran crisis, they sold stock worth ₹1.2 lakh crore. Foreign portfolio investors were net sellers of equities worth ₹9,484.22 crore on Thursday, while domestic institutional investors were net buyers to the tune of ₹10,041.84 crore.

Analysts are of the view that elevated crude prices, bond yields and global liquidity remain key risks.

However, continued weakness could increasingly create selective stock-specific opportunities as positioning and valuations reset.



recently, you need a watertight deal or something that comes at an attractive valuation so people feel good about how it will work out," Savvides said in an interview. Backing the biggest issuers proved to be a winning strategy. SpaceX and

SK Hynix are up 12% and 24% respectively since their debuts, lifting the weighted average return from this year's US IPO class to 8.8%, data compiled by Bloomberg show. The performance of many smaller IPOs has been lackluster, as



ET Q&A

DAVID A RICKS
CHAIRMAN & CEO, ELI LILLY

AI's Promise is Ahead of Us... It's Enhancing the Speed and Efficiency Now

On the back of a global boom in anti-obesity drugs and its blockbuster formulations such as Mounjaro, Eli Lilly has seen its market capitalisation surge five times in six years, and is now the only pharma giant with more than \$1 trillion in market cap. Chairman and CEO David A Ricks told **Vikas Dandekar** and **Sruthijith KK** in an interview that the company plans to remain the market leader in the anti-obesity drugs market with the help of innovation. He said the biotech industry in India holds tremendous promise and the company is always exploring possibilities here, in terms of manufacturing and acquisitions. Edited excerpts:

After the expiry of the semaglutide patents, while Mounjaro has experienced a lot of value growth, Lilly's market share has eroded in GLP-1. Should we conclude that the Indian market will prioritise cost over efficacy?

No, I think. Because India is not the only market with generics, but in every case, what we've seen is that generics bring in new patients because of the price points. I think we've seen it in India, true in Brazil, and we have the situation in Canada. We see, month by month, growth for Mounjaro continues.

Last year, when you spoke to ET, you spoke about 10 weight-loss drugs being in the pipeline. There's a lot of interest in retatrutide and bimagrumab. Where do they stand in terms of trials, latest results, whether they're likely to arrive in markets?

It's a good week to talk about it. We just had a big day for retatrutide (in terms of trial results). We're setting a new benchmark for both weight-loss and other important cardiovascular markers, in both people with diabetes and people without diabetes, but with elevated BMI. We also announced some exciting data today (Thursday) for Foundayo (Eli Lilly's daily oral weight-loss pill). This was the longest study done to date, really looking at cardiovascular safety in people with diabetes. The results are strong. We had a 53% reduction in cardiovascular mortality. So, 53% less deaths than the standard-of-care for diabetes, which was measured against Lantus, or the commonly used insulin. So, that's encouraging. We announced a test for a new triple-acting medicine we call eloralintide + tirzepatide combination. This combines eloralintide, which is our phase 3 amylin agonist, with tirzepatide, the ingredient in Moun-

jaro—kind of a triple-acting medicine with two peptides in it but will be co-formulated in one injection. There are several other projects, but the 10 number is a good number.

It suddenly seems like we have entered an era of miracle drugs. Whether it is Alzheimer's drugs that are able to clear amyloid plaques from brain cells, the kind of longevity impact that some of these drugs are having, etc. From your vantage as a pharma veteran, did a steady curve of progress get us here, or has there been an acceleration?

I think there has been an acceleration in innovation in our industry. I think maybe all great inventions appear to be a miracle when they first unfold. For many people, Mounjaro and drugs like this are feeling that way because they've suffered from a condition all their life. The reality is

SHAPING PUBLIC POLICY

I think the role we play, and this is two-sided, in helping shape public policy about healthcare has changed

our genetic background pre-programmes us to conserve calories. Our ancestors grew up in starvation. And so there aren't many mechanisms to cause us to feel full. One of them is GLP-1. Boosting that signal has made a profound difference for many, many people. The tools we're using to discover new breakthroughs have changed in the last 15 years, I think. And we have many more tools, and the way we can wield those instruments to apply those tools has gotten much more precise.

Your company has gone from market cap of under \$200 billion to upwards of a trillion dollars in a matter of six years. How does it complicate matters for you in terms of internal dynamics, compensation, incentive structures? How difficult is it to run a company that is undergoing a massive re-rating in the public markets?

Probably less difficult than a company that had a massive re-rating in the other direction. I think there are some challenges, but mostly positive. I mean, the recognition of the company has risen with that. Many, many retail investors have bought our stock because they like the product. I think the role we play, and this is two-sided, in helping shape public policy about healthcare has changed. We're considered the leader in the industry, and we are called upon to advise governments, sometimes to complain about governments, and that gets picked up by the media more.

At the same time, our industry can be a key driver of intellectual property, growth, high-value jobs, reindustrialisation, things that are priorities to the government as well.

Often we sit on both sides of a complicated equation, and Lilly's often asked to participate in that. You know, inside the company, of course, we do have stock-based compensation schemes, and I think Lilly employees have done extremely well during this period. This will allow some of our people to retire early, and we are okay with that if that's what they want, but equally there are now more and more people who want to work with us.

There is a lot of talk on AI's ability to revolutionise drug discovery, personalise medicine through genomics and so on. Behind the scenes, have you started seeing the results, or is most of AI's promise still ahead of us?

Most of the promise is ahead of us. I think what we've been able to do, and Lilly's really a leader here—I think we've leaned into AI more than most—is to build tools that can help our scientists predict experiment results.

But this is not like, I think the public thinks, okay, we'll fire up some AI, and we'll enter a question like, "Cure pancreatic cancer." And it will think for a while, and then come back with a molecule that will do this. This is far from the reality today. But what we can do is to say, okay, here's a type of new drug, an antibody, let's say. And we've made a thousand of them for a single target. Which one, given its structure, is likely to cause problems with immune reaction, or it'll be too short-acting?

And, because we've done a lot of experiments to look at different structures and predict this in actual laboratory experiments, the machines can look at all that data and apply the kind of rules of that system and help us stop working on drugs that won't make it. So that creates efficiency and speed. I think what is happening now with technology is it's really enhancing the speed and efficiency of using the normal laboratory tools we use. It isn't giving us new insights, necessarily, to create breakthroughs, but helping the process of discovery go more smoothly and more cheaply.

Tell us about how you look at India as a market, as a potential source for acquisitions, as a potential manufacturing destination, and in other ways?

We have a complex and large presence here. Let's start with the marketplace. As the wealth of the country grows, spending on healthcare rises, and that means our products will do well. Mounjaro has been in the news here, and a big success. We're investing to reach



COMPANY PHOTO

more patients, to partner with physicians and hospitals, to improve care, in particular, in cardiometabolic health. Because of the pipeline we discussed already, we're in a unique position to change the trajectory of disease in India in that space.

We do have manufacturing partnerships, but it's not in the way you think. It's not just a purchase order and a shipment. These are highly

Your company is growing in volume, but there are concerns on price realisation. As US prices converge with the rest of the world, what is the future of Lilly going to look like?

In our sector, pricing is a concern, in part because the public often bears part of that, either through taxation or direct expense, and it's always hard to sell a product. If it's highly

INDUSTRY IS A BIG DRIVER

Our industry can be a key driver of IP, growth, high-value jobs, reindustrialisation, things that are priorities to govt

priced, people don't like that. But, research is expensive, and we sell, fund research with our own capital base, and there wouldn't be any Eli Lilly or future drugs if we don't have prices that are above our cost. So that's a reality, and we have to manage that tension.

There have been historic differences between the US and every other developed country, and the Trump administration wants to address that.

We've signed an arrangement to do so. I think we're happier if price points are more similar across countries, kind of by income level. That's our concept: higher-income countries should pay a little more for that research, and for the same product, lower-income countries can pay a little less. This can help expand access in lower-income countries, which is a good thing. We want to get our drugs to as many patients as possible, and at the same time fund the research apparatus.

On my list of concerns, this is not super high. To be honest, we're managing it just fine, and one reality with obesity medications is the lower the prices, the more people we tend to reach.

You just announced the Lilly Change the Course Commitment.

This is an important new pledge from the company. Four out of seven people with obesity live in low- and middle-income countries. And India is one of those countries. Yet, for every five people on an incretin today, four of them live in wealthy countries. So the penetration, use rate, of these breakthrough medicines is really underdeveloped in the poorest countries of the world. And we're pledging to equalise those.

PAYING FOR RESEARCH

Higher-income nations should pay more for research... for same product, lower-income countries can pay less

It has great science, great talent base, a lot of knowhow and a manufacturing base for laboratory sciences. But the funding environment here isn't great.

The venture environment and also the ecosystem, which China really mastered—people do clinical trials, the ecosystem for animal experiments, laboratories... It's not as well developed here.

Car Cos Drive Out More as Festive Days Draw Near

HOT WHEELS Estimates peg Sept dispatches at 460,000; lower tax rates expected to help

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Auto makers posted strong double-digit growth in September sales, as they ramped up dispatches from factories anticipating robust demand in the festive period.

According to industry estimates, car manufacturers dispatched as many as 460,000 hatchbacks, sedans and utility vehicles to dealerships last month, about 21% more compared with 378,000 units a year earlier.

Market leader Maruti Suzuki outperformed the industry, with sales growing 37% to 181,838 units.

Demand remains strong as the country heads into the festive season, said Partho Banerjee, Maruti Suzuki's senior executive officer for marketing and sales. "We do not see any headwinds and expect demand to remain strong, as far as we are concerned, this festive season," he said. The company's stock is enough to meet only 17 days of sales, he said.

There are primarily three tailwinds at work buoying demand: the reduction in GST rates from late September last year; the policy rate cuts that lowered interest rates and income-tax relief to those earning up to ₹11 lakh per annum, he said.

Tata Motors posted a 15% increase in passenger vehicle sales to 68,810 units last month. At rival Mahindra & Mahindra, sales rose 14% to 64,092 units. Despite being a soft quarter, passenger vehicle demand during the July-September period sustained the strong momentum seen after the GST 2.0 reform, said Shailash Chandra, managing director and chief executive officer at Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles.

Industrywide, volumes, as per data from the government's Vahan portal, grew around 24% in the quarter from a year earlier: "led by increasing adoption of greener powertrains, providing a promising backdrop for the forthcoming festive season", he said.

Hyundai Motor reported an 11% increase in wholesale volume to 57,166 units in the local market.

Including exports, sales in the past month rose 10.8% to 77,916 units, the highest ever for a month for the Indian unit of the Korean automaker; Hyundai Motor India MD and CEO Tarun Garg said. "We are expecting sustained customer enthusiasm during the festive season," he said.

At Kia India, sales volume rose 41% to 32,017 units in September.

Toyota Kirloskar Motor and Renault, however, posted lower sales with an 8% and a 20% fall, respectively. In the commercial vehicle segment, demand remained healthy, with market leader Tata Motors

Pole Position

Category	Sept 2026	% chg
Maruti Suzuki	181,838	37
Tata Motors	68,810	15
M&M	64,092	14
Hyundai India	57,166	11
Kia India	32,017	41
Toyota Kirloskar	25,027	-7.6
JSW MG Motor	8,018	19
Renault	3,399	-20
Nissan	3,300	103

Domestic sales only
Source: Companies
Diesel prices, rate hikes, global woes remain concerns

posting a 31% increase in volumes to 43,487 units in September; Girish Wagh, MD and CEO of Tata Motors, said the growth registered last quarter was broad-based, reflecting healthy demand across the economy. Rivals Ashok Leyland posted 29% growth to 22,157 units. At VE Commercial Vehicles, sales of Eicher trucks rose 57.5% to 10,479 units. Commodity costs remain a significant concern, industry executives said. Diesel prices, potential interest rate hikes and global uncertainties are key monitorables.

"While the high H2 base could moderate growth rates, industry fundamentals remain supportive," Wagh said. In the two-wheeler segment, Honda Motorcycle & Scooter

India posted a 26% increase in sales to 636,768 units last month. At Chennai-based TVS Motor Co, two-wheeler sales grew 17% to

482,073 units. Bajaj Auto, though, saw a decline of 12%, selling 239,771 units last month in the local market. At the premium end of the market, Royal Enfield reported 7% growth, selling 121,326 units.

In the farm equipment segment, market leader Mahindra saw tractor sales decline 23% to 50,208 units last month. Veeraj Nakra, president of the Farm Equipment Business, said: "The joy decline in volumes is primarily attributable to the festive season shift, commencing in October this year, as compared with September last year. The comparison is also impacted by a higher base in September 2025, which benefited from the implementation of the GST rate cut during the period."

Electric Car Sales Double as Fresh Models, Infra Help

Fully Charged EV Industry - Sep YoY Sales & Market Share

TOP 5 EV MANUFACTURERS

Rank	MFR	SALES		YoY Growth (%)	MARKET SHARE (%)	
		Sep CV'25	Sep CV'26		Sep CV'25	Sep CV'26
1	Tata	7,365	14,721	99.9	41.1	42.2
2	Mahindra	3,972	7,743	94.9	22.2	22.2
3	MG	4,800	5,226	8.9	26.8	15.0
4	VinFast	6	2,961	49250.0	0.0	8.5
5	KIA	598	1,255	109.9	3.3	3.6
Top 5 Subtotal		16,741	31,906	90.6	93.4	91.4

Source: EV Market Sales Analysis

Shally Seth Mohile

Mumbai: Extending the previous months' momentum, India's electric car market nearly doubled in September, with sales surging 95% to 34,894 units from 17,924 units a year ago, showed data from the government's Vahan portal.

Penetration of electrics in the passenger vehicle market rose to 8.2% in September from 5.7% a year earlier. E-car sales have been advancing every month since March, with the exception of August when sales fell sequentially.

Besides geopolitical tensions triggering a spike in fuel prices, EV sales are getting support from an improving charging infrastructure and the launch of newer models across price points.

EV market leader Tata Motors retained its lead at 42.2% share, while Mahindra held 22.2%. VinFast surged to an 8.5% share in its first full year, while Maruti Suzuki entered the market with a 3.1% share.

Despite an 8.9% volume growth, JSW MG saw its share fall to 15% as competition intensified. Registrations in the first nine months of the calendar year advanced 83% to 248,890 units from 135,682 units a year earlier.

Tata Motors crossed the 100,000-unit mark for the first time since it entered the market in

2020, with a 40.9% year to date share. Mahindra was the biggest gainer among the earlier entrants, adding 4.6 percentage points to reach 23.3%. VinFast and Maruti have captured 5% and 4.3% YTD share, respectively, pointing to a rapidly changing competitive landscape, the data showed.

Among the other established brands, BYD's September sales rose 13.5% yoy to 831 units, but its market share declined to 2.4% from 4.1% a year earlier. For the first nine months, BYD sales grew 17.3% to 5,684 units, taking its share to 2.3% from 3.6%. Hyundai also lost ground, with YTD sales declining 18.3% to 4,972 units and its share falling to 2%.

The widening field of competitors is altering the market's competitive structure. Tata and Mahindra together accounted for 64.4% of September sales, broadly stable from 63.3% a year earlier, even as newer entrants gained ground.

On a YTD basis, the two together accounted for 64.2% of the market, up from 58.3% a year earlier. VinFast and Maruti have quickly built meaningful shares, while the established players are growing at sharply different rates as the overall market expands.



Weekends Turn Busy for City Hotels

Rising weekend occupancies hints that Indian hotel market may be maturing

Anumeha Chaturvedi

New Delhi: Historically, weekend demand at city hotels in India has been weak for the country's hospitality sector unlike global gateway cities such as London, New York, Sydney and Melbourne. But, thanks to rising staycations and weekend travel, that seems to be changing in what is being perceived as a sign of a maturing hotel market.

Karan Mahesh, regional director, South and Southeast Asia, STR, CoStar Group, said nationwide Friday-Saturday occupancy reached almost 67% for the January-August period in India, the highest level since 2023.

Mahesh said 16 of the 17 Indian markets tracked in this dataset recorded higher weekend occupancies in 2026. "Mumbai's weekend occupancy rose 2.9 percentage points to 77.2%, compared with a 1.3 percentage point increase on other days. New Delhi's weekend occupancy increased by 3.9 points to 77.4%, slightly ahead of

its weekday improvement," he said, adding that a business destination's ability to attract weekend demand is an important indicator of market maturity.

In September this year, Ibis and Ibis Styles properties saw weekend occupancies increase by 5-7%. Average daily rates for properties of the brands went up 16-18% year on year on weekends. Animesh Kumar, commercial head for Ibis and Ibis Styles India said the demand has been going up thanks to guests



VARANI SAHU

NCLT Junks Insolvency Plea Against Shapoorji Pallonji

Kailash Babar & Maulik Vyas

Mumbai: The National Company Law Tribunal rejected a petition filed by Union Infra seeking initiation of bankruptcy proceedings against Shapoorji Pallonji & Co over an alleged default of ₹4.31 crore.

Union Infra filed the petition under Section 9 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code, which allows an operational creditor

to seek bankruptcy proceedings. It alleged that Shapoorji Pallonji & Co did not pay it for the work carried out for resurfacing damaged cement concrete roads in Nellore, Andhra Pradesh.

The tribunal held that its claim did not meet the requirements for initiating bankruptcy proceedings. One of the two invoices produced by the petitioner was from a period when the govern-

ment had placed a ban on filing of bankruptcy cases to lessen the economic distress of Covid. The remaining claim, the tribunal said, did not meet the ₹1 crore threshold to initiate the proceedings.

Union Infra argued that Shapoorji Pallonji received payments from the state's public health and municipal engineering department and was therefore required to release payments under the terms governing the project.

SUITS & SAYINGS

ET's roundup of the wackiest whispers in corporate corridors

Brothers Reunite



The fraternal fault lines inside this new-age mobility group have made their way into this column before. Now as the company hits another rough patch, there's a fresh turn in the family saga. We hear the younger brother has returned to Big B's den after spending several months away from the turmoil. With market share slipping and the executive ranks thinning, the founder appears to have decided that bygones are best left as bygones. In his second coming, the younger sibling is expected to take charge of the group's flagship legacy business, which finds itself squeezed between a global heavyweight and an aggressive homegrown upstart. For now, though, both brothers are keeping conspicuously out of the limelight. When the road gets this bumpy, perhaps it helps to have family back in the passenger seat.

Exit Fears



The thaw in India-China ties may be gathering pace, but some startup founders are not quite ready to pack their bags. We hear a leading venture firm's proposed China tech tour has seen a few invitees quietly drop out, despite seemingly propitious timing. The hesitation has less to do with getting into China than getting out. Beijing has tightened its use of exit restrictions, and earlier this year two Chinese cofounders of a Singapore-based AI startup were reportedly prevented from leaving after being summoned by regulators. Indian founders may have little reason to expect similar treatment. But for some, apparently, a tech tour is not the place to test the proposition.

Privy to the whispers in power corridors or juicy tips on India Inc? Do share with us at etsuits.sayings@timesofindia.com

‘Productivity growth in consumer services is powering India’s rise’

Dani Rodrik is Ford Foundation Professor of International Political Economy at Harvard Kennedy School. Speaking with **Srijana Mitra Das** in **ET Evoke**, Rodrik outlines crucial new ways the global economy will now develop – which don't involve 'hyperglobalisation' or export-focused manufacturing:



Q. In your new book, 'Shared Prosperity in a Fractured World', why do you see ending poverty, boosting the middle class globally and tackling climate change as three interlinked challenges?

A. They are related because many of the policies we undertake at one front have important spillovers into the other agendas. For instance, advanced countries trying to protect their middle classes through trade restrictions have an effect on poverty reduction in developing countries that may be trying to export. Similarly, policies to decarbonise may have adverse implications for prospects of industrialisation in low- and middle-income countries. So, an important objective of my book is to present an agenda where we can avoid such cruel trade-offs and pursue policies that can mutually benefit all three of these very important goals.



Q. Why do you emphasise services – and not manufacturing – will be the new motor of the global economic system?

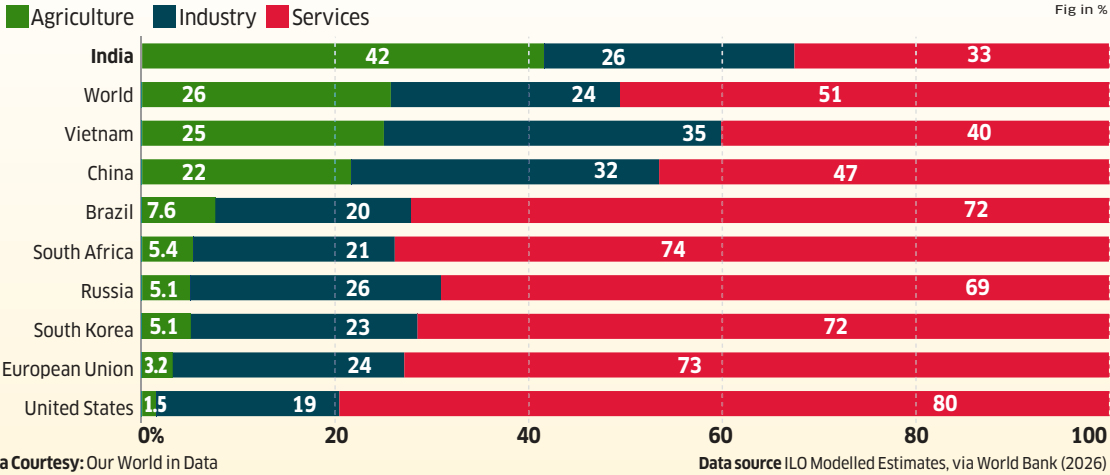
A. That is just an acknowledgement of reality. A lot of my research focused on the advantages of industrialisation and how the promotion of manufacturing was critical historically to all important instances seen of growth and development. However, it has become clear, looking at the evidence from the last couple of decades, that the nature of manufacturing industries has changed significantly today – manufacturing is no longer a labour-absorbing sector for even low-income countries, especially the kind of work that could propel you into middle-income and higher levels because that requires participation in global value chains and building up technological and infrastructural capabilities many low-income countries do not have. So, even when countries are successful in plugging into certain segments of value chains, we see how they tend to get stuck there and this does not diffuse or create broader linkages and upgrading which earlier generations of industrialisers experienced.

Ploughing A Lonely Furrow? Agriculture can support fewer numbers productively



So, What Do You Do? Employment Share in Agriculture, Industry & Services

Distribution of total employment between agriculture, industry and services sectors, as seen in 2025 data. (Here, economic sectors are classified by the main activity of the workplace, not specific tasks a worker performs)



All Data Courtesy: Our World in Data

Data source: ILO Modelled Estimates, via World Bank (2026)

Finally, Service With A Smile?

At different times, diverse sectors shaped the fate of nations. While highly productive agriculture made some countries a focus of colonial extraction in earlier eras, post-WWII modernity was first defined by export-based manufacturing activity. Today, Rodrik and other economists argue those days are gone – further growth will come from job-generating services

The data tells me no countries going forward will be able to produce the kind of manufacturing jobs in the numbers and quantities that countries in East Asia or older advanced economies did. Hence, when we ask, how can we increase the productivity of workers in the jobs they are going to have, that's mostly going to be in services – the real challenge of development here onwards will be finding ways of increasing productivity in labour-absorbing services.

Q. These are profitable avenues for capital but what could make services truly equitable for the people who actually work them?

A. The good news is many services are going through a productivity revolution – that has been enabled, on the one hand, by new digital technologies and platforms that have significantly increased productivity in retail, delivery and personal services. There have also been many organisational innovations here – for example, retail services are delivered through discount chains that can cut overheads and have much better inventory management, again, using new digital technologies and reaching larger mass markets at lower prices. When you look closely at grocery stores, food services or retail and delivery, you find measured productivity increases that are quite significant – for example, in the United States, productivity growth in the last 15 years in these services outpaced manufacturing. So, the old idea that services are stagnant and don't experience productivity growth is no longer true.

when there is productivity growth in these middle-class services or local consumer services that can generate a lot of jobs, that's very good news for development. These nascent trends in technology and organisational innovation suggest productivity growth is certainly possible in these services – but it will require policies to ensure that these benefits can be reaped and generalised. What we have seen so far, say, in food delivery or retail, is platform companies essentially reaping the majority of the gains on profits from innovation. Therefore, it's very important for countervailing forces, whether that is government regulation, competition policy or the voice of workers and bargaining power, to ensure productivity gains are distributed widely.

Also, we need a version of industrial policy that is much more geared towards services. Often, government officials ask manufacturing companies – what do you need to invest or expand? We need the same kind of collaboration now with

retail chains, platforms, local companies and entrepreneurs in services to provide them with the public inputs they need to expand and generate more productive employment.

That's the upside – but I don't think it's automatically the way AI is used and will be deployed for the benefit of society at large. Maintaining a certain degree of social and political control over the direction of AI and how it is deployed is very important – and there, we have a lot of question marks.

Q. It's commonly thought China's economic success relies most heavily on manufacturing – what would an enormous shift to services imply for it?

A. Even in China, we now have a significant shift taking place – China has been losing employment in manufacturing now for more than a decade. We have tens of millions of fewer workers in manufacturing in China compared to two decades ago. China was an outstanding example in history though, the most significant instance of growth driven through industrialisation, particularly export-oriented – I just don't think any other country in the future will be able to replicate anything like that. The most important lesson to derive from China is that you need its judicious combination of market forces and state guidance to ensure you're positioning your economy for productive upgrading. If you look at China and take the lesson that you should pour all your resources into industrialisation and promote manufacturing towards exports, that is the wrong lesson going forward.

Q. Are you hopeful for India, given its services revolution today?

A. India's services revolution is very important. It's a very inspiring example for other nations.

Q. Are you hopeful about the prospects of AI in a services-based economy?

A. AI has an advantage which is unlike earlier waves of technological innovation, such as automation, robots and computing – it need not directly replace workers. When you install robots in a factory, they're basically meant to displace workers, so they are directly labour-displacing. In contrast, AI essentially enables all workers to take advantage of its accumulated knowledge and experience of the frontier. So, in principle, it can greatly benefit less skilled, less experienced, less educated workers.

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Q. Are you hopeful for India, given its services revolution today?

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Q. Can you also share your argument on the middle class globally boosting democracy?

A. It's an idea that goes back to the ancient Greeks – you cannot have a broadly participatory and democratic society without a large middle class. Both common sense and historical evidence point in that direction – when incomes and wealth get polarised between the very rich and very poor, the very rich don't have any interest in sharing power and the very poor are not interested in maintaining any rules of the game. So, you have political instability, polarisation and many of the ills that our societies and polities are facing today.

The erosion of our democracies, certainly as seen in the West over the last few decades, is the result of the decline of the middle class – and the much heightened economic insecurity the middle class is facing because of the results of globalisation, automation and technological change, policies of austerity and so forth. There are similar problems in middle-income countries as well, where there isn't necessarily have a long history of democratisation but very economically insecure lower-middle classes. It's much easier for strongmen or demagogues to appeal to them and point to supposed 'enemies of the people' to mobilise mass political support.

Q. Your earlier work became known for your idea of the 'trilemma' of the world economy, starting in the heyday of globalisation. How do you see that in today's Trumpian world?

A. The trilemma was a useful framework to understand how we got here. I think our current crisis is, in many ways, the result of not having recognised the trade-offs the trilemma posed, namely that if you're simultaneously trying to push for deeper integration and hyperglobalisation, without significantly strengthening the democracy of global institutions and their governance, then ultimately, that democracy will suffer at home. That's what we see today. Now, essentially, different countries are going very different ways. China is pushing on its globalisation strategy without particularly caring about democracy at home. Democracy is suffering very badly in the United States and in parts of Europe. It's not just that we pushed back on hyperglobalisation – democracy has taken a hit as well and that's the tragedy of not having paid attention to the trade-offs implied by that trilemma.

Views expressed are personal
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BID TO ADDRESS RECURRING GRIEVANCES

RBI asks Banks to Fix Complaint Gaps

Regulator flags systemic flaws, complaints under ombudsman scheme up 13.5%

Dheeraj Tiwari

New Delhi: The Reserve Bank of India has asked banks to strengthen their systems to address recurring customer complaints and gaps in regulatory compliance. At a meeting held last month, the regulator asked banks to identify underlying systemic, process-related and operational issues contributing to complaints and undertake root-cause analysis of recurring complaints, said people familiar with the matter.

“The regulator reiterated some of the concerns and also shared major complaint categories based on complaints handled by RBI ombudsman offices,” said an executive, requesting anonymity.

“The regulator has called for identifying and implementing appropriate measures to bring down recurrence of such complaints,” he added. More than 1.33 million complaints were received in fiscal 2025 under the RBI's ombudsman scheme, a 13.55% increase from the previous year.

Fixing the Framework

Complaints against banks in FY25: **2,41,601** or **81.53%** of the total received against financial institutions

Complaints received against private sector banks: **34.39%**

Complaints against NBFCs: **43,864**, or **14.80%** of total

“Another suggestion was to build capacities, including industry-level training programmes, for effective handling and resolution of such complaints,” said another executive. “We will be discussing this internally and finding a mechanism including capacity building at the industry

level, besides each bank board will formulate their own strategies as per the RBI overall directives,” he added.

At the annual conference of the internal ombudsmen of banks and other RBI-regulated entities and in July, central bank deputy governor Swaminathan J noted that a significant proportion of complaints resolved in favour of customers at the RBI ombudsman level were not referred to the internal ombudsman in the first place.

“This is a matter of serious concern because it undermines the very purpose of the internal ombudsman framework,” he said, requesting regulated entities to review their internal grievance redress processes carefully and asking their IOs to identify recurring issues and help implement remedial measures.

Complaint management systems should be designed to prevent complaints from inadvertently bypassing the internal ombudsman process due to classification issues or process deficiencies, he said.

The Reserve Bank-Integrated Ombudsman Scheme, 2026 (RB-IOS, 2026), came into effect in July 2026, under which jurisdiction-neutral handling of complaints under the “One Nation One Ombudsman” approach was put into place.

JURISDICTION NO BAR: ONE FRAMEWORK FOR ALL COMPLAINTS
RB-IOS 2026, effective July, introduced jurisdiction-neutral complaint handling under the ‘One Nation, One Ombudsman’ framework

Petrol, Diesel Sales Rise in Sept; LPG Demand Falls 9%

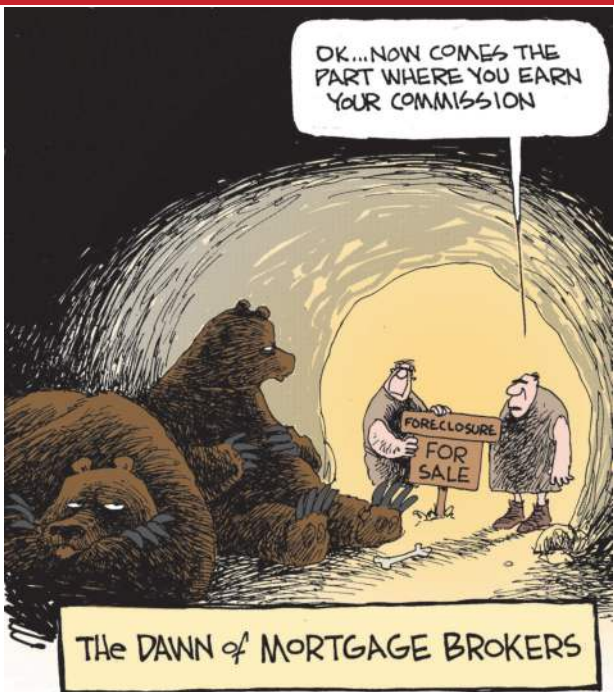
Our Bureau

New Delhi: Petrol and diesel sales rose 7.2% and 4.9%, respectively, year-on-year in September, while aviation turbine fuel (ATF) sales were flat and LPG sales fell 9%, according to oil ministry data.



Higher vehicle sales supported petrol consumption, while below-normal monsoon rainfall boosted diesel use for irrigation. Increased economic activity also contributed to higher diesel demand for mobility. Flat ATF sales point to subdued growth in air traffic. LPG consumption, predominantly used for cooking in India, fell in September, extending a decline that began after the war disrupted supplies.

NON-SEQUITUR



Vedanta Bets on Mangla, Northeast for Growth

Plans \$200 m investment in Rajasthan fields in FY27, targets 150,000 barrels a day from Mangla

Prashant Mukherjee

Barmer: Vedanta Oil and Gas is increasing investment in its mature Rajasthan fields to arrest natural reservoir decline and boost crude output from existing wells. Simultaneously, the company is developing the northeast region into a new hub for gas growth. The company, formerly known as Cairn India, plans to invest about \$200 million (\$2,000 crore) in 2026-27 across northern Rajasthan, comprising the Mangla, Bhagyam and Aishwariya fields.

The immediate focus is Mangla, the field that transformed Barmer into India's biggest onshore oil-producing region after its discovery in 2004. Vedanta is targeting production of more than 150,000 barrels a day (bpd) from Mangla, up from about 80,000 bpd currently, through polymer flooding, well interventions and other enhanced-recovery measures.

Jim Johnny Gast, interim CEO and whole-time director of Vedanta Oil

BUILDING THE NEXT ENGINE

Rajasthan Fields

Current output **80,000 bpd**
Target: **150,000+ bpd**

Recovery achieved **41%**
Recovery target: **60%**

Key tools: Polymer flooding | ASP injection | Well interventions

and Gas, said producing fields were experiencing natural declines of 13%, making higher recovery from existing wells critical to increasing output.

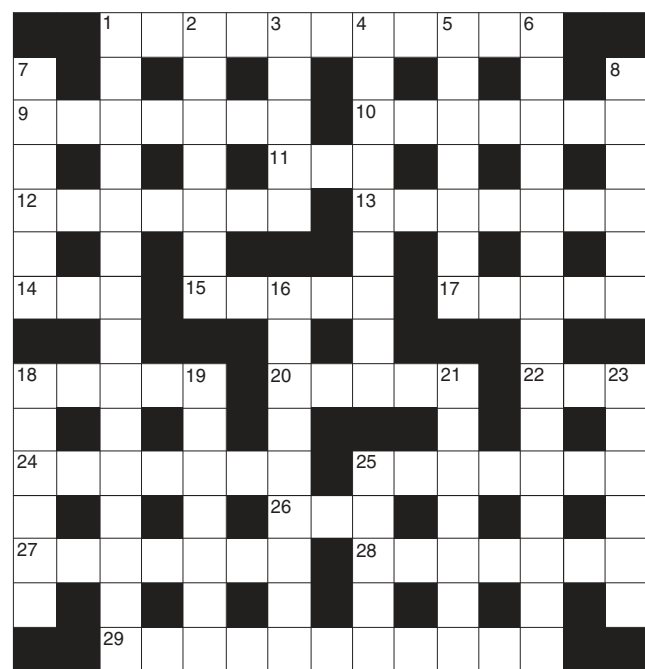
“Over the last 20 years, the country's total crude production has remained stagnant at 0.87-0.99 mmbob (million barrels of oil equivalent), while consumption has gone from 2.65 to 5.6 mmbob – almost doubled. We are trying to explore the small sedimentary basins which have vast opportunity and increase production from our producing wells, which will reduce this huge gap,” Gast told

media persons in Barmer. The company is expanding enhanced oil recovery at Mangla through polymer flooding and alkaline-surfactant-polymer injection. Recovery from producing wells has reached 41%, and the company has set a target of achieving 60%, Gast said.

Beyond Rajasthan, Vedanta is building its northeast portfolio as another growth engine. The company holds nine blocks under

Crossword

9719



plants (7)
29 Search former place linked to speech (11)

DOWN

- Note angelic girl at work in school for a profession? (8,7)
- Reasonable note in bars? (7)
- Anger over tips for naive female (5)
- Awful wreck by seabird somewhere in Somerset (9)
- Disentangles ruse Len devised (7)
- Northern boatman at sea naturally suited for a role (2,3,6,4)
- Marooned around river and hit? (6)
- Destroy small bed in school (6)
- Get rid of top ad I distributed in support of place (3,4,2)
- Discard note caught in stream (6)
- Attract new unseen piece firstly prepared in draft form (5,2)
- Clever use of words with punch by first person in Asian language (7)
- Site over time for crop destroying insect (6)
- Greek character enjoying Amman? Not entirely (5)

ACROSS

- Place with service at the start? (6,5)
- Hot snack prepared at site around ring (7)
- Unpredictable rodent among spilt rice (7)
- Wintry weather with no sun currently (3)
- Rattle Arsenal player losing head over losing wingers (7)
- Seek ten for playing, being most enthusiastic (7)
- Snubbed generous family (3)
- Outcast found in trouble,

- perhaps (5)
- Break up overhead (5)
- Expert entering road was in a hurry (5)
- Fool in Belgian city dropping article (5)
- Love long river with no end of wildlife (3)
- Recall a secure university with Jack for female (7)
- Common thing passed on by Republican in charge (7)
- Woman in draw on a regular basis (3)
- Fancy candle around back of ledge freed from dirt (7)
- Dome was built in open fields with

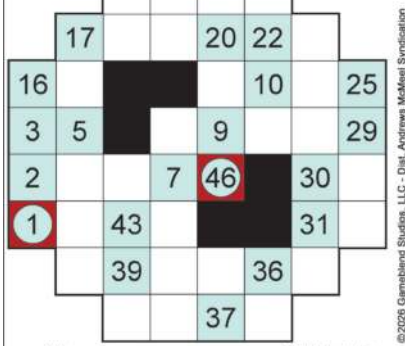
SOLUTION TO No. 9718:

- ACROSS: 1 Balletic. 5 Awaits. 9 Coolness. 10 Kendal. 12 Uber. 13 Floodlight. 15 Draining board. 19 Martial artist. 23 Recitation. 25 Mere. 28 Chilly. 29 Metaphor. 30 DeeJay. 31 By chance. DOWN: 1 Bochum. 2 Loose. 3 Edna. 4 Insulin. 6 Wheel. 7 Indignant. 8 Solitude. 11 Coin. 14 Raki. 15 Directive. 16 Ira. 17 Blip. 18 Embraced. 20 Late. 21 Rookery. 22 Degree. 24 Tulsa. 26 Ethan. 27 Dash.

HIDATO

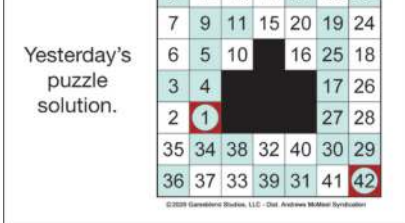
FIND THE PATH - SOLVE THE PUZZLE

Complete the grid so that numbers 1-46 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally.



www.hidato.com

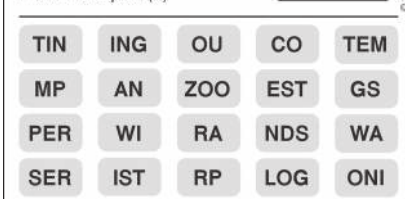
©2026 Gambleware Studios, LLC. All Rights Reserved. Synonym: 105



7 LITTLE WORDS

Find the 7 words to match the 7 clues. The numbers in parentheses represent the number of letters in each solution. Each letter combination can be used only once, but all letter combinations will be necessary to complete the puzzle.

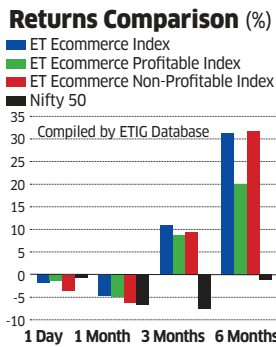
- | CLUES | SOLUTIONS |
|------------------------------------|-----------|
| 1 chemists' concoctions (9) | |
| 2 toughening, as sword steel (9) | |
| 3 certain Baltic State citizen (8) | |
| 4 G and PG (7) | |
| 5 more sagacious (5) | |
| 6 become twisted (4) | |
| 7 animal expert (9) | |



Yesterday's Answers: 1. GRAVITATES 2. HEAR 3. CHIEF 4. PERCEIVED 5. COURTYARD 6. PRAGMATIC 7. BLUEISH 11/13

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When you look at culture under a microscope, you'll see stories

Tech Buzz
OpenAI Blames Moonshot for Mass Data Swipe



BEIJING: OpenAI accused its Chinese rival Moonshot AI of being responsible for a wide-scale effort to extract data from its GPT artificial intelligence systems that could be used to reproduce the reasoning and capabilities of the company's most advanced models. OpenAI disclosed that it observed thousands of attempts by users associated with Moonshot to decipher hidden information about how its models reason through problems. Coordinated efforts to glean the data began in July, peaking at 16,000 requests. Though it couldn't attribute all the operators to a single actor, OpenAI said that users associated with Moonshot played a significant role. OpenAI's accusations add to a growing pile of claims that Chinese AI is extracting proprietary knowledge from US firms. —Bloomberg

22.9M
Projected global foldable smartphone shipments in 2026, up 13% YoY, according to IDC

WhatsApp Adds Parental Controls for Teenager A/cs



NEW DELHI: WhatsApp has announced a new set of optional parental controls for teenagers, giving parents greater control over their teens' privacy settings, group activity, Channels and Meta AI experience on the messaging platform. The company said the new controls are designed to help parents and teenagers decide together how they want to use WhatsApp, while keeping personal conversations protected. Under the new controls, parents will be able to select privacy settings for their teens, including who can view their profile photo and who can add them to groups. If teenagers want to loosen any of these settings, they will require approval through a parent-set PIN. Parents will be notified when their teen joins or leaves a group, or when the size of a group increases significantly, the firm said. —Agencies

Deal Corner Top deals of the day

Chip Firm Agrani Eyes ₹850cr from Samsung, 360 One, Peak, Others

AI semicon firm may seek around ₹120-130cr from govt-backed RDI scheme as part of raise

Nikhil Patwardhan & Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: South Korean conglomerate Samsung, 360 One Asset Management, and existing backer Peak XV Partners are in talks to participate in the ₹800-850 crore funding round of artificial intelligence semiconductor startup Agrani Labs, people aware of the matter told ET.

The Bengaluru-based company is also looking to apply for around ₹120-130 crore under the government-backed Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) scheme as part of the overall fundraising, the people said.

Meanwhile, Peak XV is likely to invest around ₹180-200 crore in the round. Samsung's and 360 One's investments could not be ascertained immediately. The round is expected to value Agrani Labs at around ₹2,400-2,500 crore post-money, at least three people said.

Agrani was founded by former Intel and AMD executives Dheemanth Nagaraj, Ashok Jagannathan, Srikanth Nimmagadda and Rajesh Vivekanandham. The company is developing high-performance artificial intelligence (AI) graphics processing units (GPUs) and a complete software ecosystem for data centres.

Peak XV, 360 One, and Agrani declined comment, while Samsung did not respond to queries. The startup emerged

from stealth earlier this year after raising an \$8 million seed round led by Peak XV. At the time the company said it was building chips alongside compilers, libraries and system software, an approach to reduce the difficulty for customers in adopting a new chip architecture.

Agrani is focused on developing AI inference chips that can work with Nvidia's CUDA software ecosystem. At ₹800-850 crore, the funding would also be among the largest early-stage rounds raised by an Indian semiconductor startup. Agrani plans to use the fresh funds towards research and development, engineering, and manufacturing as it works towards taking its AI compute platform to market, the sources said.



The round is expected to value Agrani Labs at around ₹2,400-2,500cr post-money

Building Up
Agrani Labs is raising **₹800-850 crore** in a fresh fundraising
Samsung & 360 One Asset Management look to participate in round
Existing backer Peak XV Partners may invest around **₹180-200 crore**
Agrani Labs plans to seek **₹120-130 crore** under RDI scheme
The startup may be valued at **₹2,400-2,500 crore** post latest funding round



SBI MF Raises Swiggy Stake to 5%, Picks Up Shares Worth ₹300cr

Asset management firm bought shares at around ₹253-254 apiece on September 29

Our Bureau

New Delhi: SBI Mutual Fund, India's largest asset management company, has raised its stake in food and grocery delivery company Swiggy to above 5% purchasing 1.18 crore shares worth around ₹300 crore through open-market transactions, an exchange filing showed.

SBI Mutual Fund bought the shares at around ₹253-254 apiece on September 29, taking its holding in Swiggy from 4.7% to 5.1%.

The purchase comes at a time when Swiggy has been facing selling pressure following its transition towards becoming an Indian-owned and controlled company (IOCC), a move that led

to its exclusion from the MSCI and FTSE indices and resulted in passive fund outflows estimated at around \$400 million.

Swiggy's shares closed 4.9% down at ₹238 on Thursday, valuing the company at around ₹65,700 crore.

In August, Swiggy shareholders approved proposals to enable the company to become an IOCC, including a plan to cap foreign shareholding at 49.5%.

The restructuring is significant for Swiggy's quick-commerce business Instamart. Becoming an IOCC allows the company to operate Instamart under an inventory-led model, giving it greater control over procurement, inventory and pricing.

23%
STAKE HELD BY DOMESTIC MUTUAL FUNDS IN SWIGGY AS OF JUNE 30

TDB Halts R&D Funding Citing Flood of Proposals

ON POINT Secretary denies cash crunch, says halting new project applications to clear massive backlog of proposals

Puran Choudhary

Bengaluru: The Technology Development Board (TDB) has paused its call for proposals under the government's Research, Development and Innovation (RDI) scheme for administrative reasons, its secretary Rajesh Kumar Pathak told ET, denying that a shortage of funds had prompted the move. The board's RDI application page has been displaying a "Call Closed" message since September 30.

In a post on X, the Department of Science and Technology (DST) said, "Due to massive influx of project proposals, TDB has decided to take a 'Pause' and closed its call for the time being which will reopen shortly after assessment of all projects received till 30th Sept. 2026. The Investment Committee (IC) and TDB are working overnight to complete the evaluation process expeditiously."

TDB is one of the second-level fund managers through which the RDI scheme is being implemented.

"Our position is very clear. There is no dearth of funds. We have released whatever the applicant requested," Pathak said. "The applicant has to match 50%. Only then can we give them the matching funds. They take time to raise the matching funds from non-government resources. Once that is done, then we issue funds from our side and hence the gap."

TDB's official status report as of April shows it had received 124 project proposals under the scheme, re-

UPI Crosses 200b Transactions in Just 9 Months as MDR Looms

Digital payments network processes 205.24b transactions worth ₹261.61Lcr in Jan-Sept FY26

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: India's Unified Payments Interface (UPI) crossed 200 billion transactions in the first nine months of 2026, setting up a record year as the digital payments network enters the festive season under a new Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) regime from October 15.

UPI processed 205.24 billion transactions worth ₹261.61 lakh crore between January and September this year; up 24% in volume and 20% in value from the corresponding period last year, according to data released by the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI). In the first nine months of 2025, UPI had processed 165.48 billion transactions worth ₹218.17 lakh crore.

However, UPI volumes moderated marginally in September from a record high in August, partly because the month had one fewer day. It processed 24.07 billion transactions worth ₹29.37 lakh crore, down 1.8% from August. Transaction value also fell marginally month on month. On a year-on-year basis, transaction volumes in September rose 23%, while transaction value increased 18%.

The average daily UPI transactions crossed 800 million for the first time

in September, rising to 802 million from 791 million in August. Daily transaction value averaged ₹7,913 crore in September, up from ₹6,205 crore in August. "UPI's September totals are slightly lower than August's only because September has one less day in the month," said Reju Datta, cofounder of Cashfree Payments, adding that the rise in daily transactions came from Ganesh Chaturthi that fell in mid-September this year.

"From April to August, the money moving through UPI each day had stayed at around ₹6,000 crore even as the number of payments grew, because most new payments were small. In September, the extra payments people made were bigger than usual, which lifted the daily value clearly above that level," he noted. Monthly UPI transaction volumes

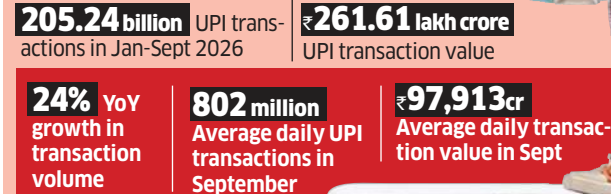
have remained above 20 billion since last October, supported by wider merchant acceptance across urban and rural markets, rising smartphone penetration and growing consumer adoption.

The data also comes against the backdrop of recent changes to the MDR framework, which have altered the economics of UPI payments for both merchants and payment service providers. MDR is the fee a merchant pays to the payment ecosystem for processing a digital transaction. Under the new framework, eligible merchant transactions above ₹2,000 will attract an MDR of 0.4%, capped at ₹300. Payments above ₹2,000 in specified sectors such as railways, telecom, insurance, fuel and agricultural inputs will instead attract a flat ₹5 MDR, while mutual fund and capital-market transactions will carry a separate 0.02% MDR, capped at ₹300.

"While the recent MDR on UPI would come into effect starting 15th October, we don't see it impacting UPI volumes or value. UPI MDR is still cheaper than those for cards and UPI has become a habit for many people due to convenience which will carry forward into the festive season as well," Datta added.

App-wise market share data for September is yet to be released. In August, however, the combined market share of PhonePe and Google Pay continued to slip and fell to 77.9% after remaining above 80% for several years, as smaller third-party UPI apps such as Navi and Supermoney stepped up cashback offers and customer acquisition efforts.

Dialling up Numbers



Govt Close to Picking Private AI Integrator for DigiLocker

Seeks to integrate high-volume commercial services across education, health, fin services

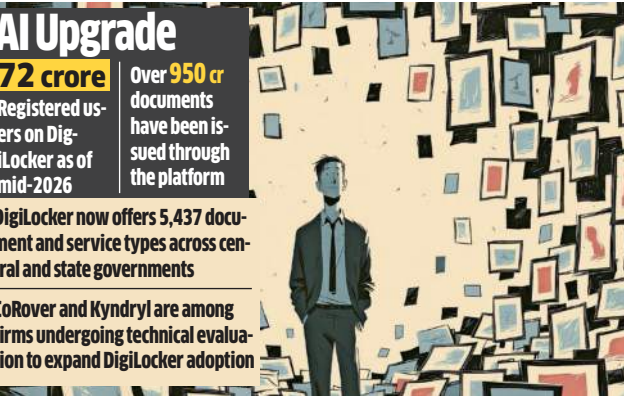
Subhayan Chakraborty

New Delhi: The government is close to empaneling private agencies to widen the DigiLocker ecosystem, and bring in more institutions who use the cloud-based platform, officials said.

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology's (MeitY) ongoing empanelment process will bring in artificial intelligence (AI) integrators who will find, onboard and integrate requestors, take the service live, as well as drive sustained transaction volumes afterwards, they added.

Launched in July, 2015 under the Digital India programme, DigiLocker provides a consent-based mechanism through which a requester can access issued documents of a citizen for delivery of a service. Beyond government bodies, requesters currently include banks, financial institutions for loan processing, educational institutions for student admissions, as well as telecom providers and corporate employers for know your customer norms.

As of mid-2026, DigiLocker crossed over 72 crore registered users and features 5,437 document or service types, including 661 central and 4,776 state services. While more than 950 crore



documents have been issued so far, the platform can deliver much more, officials said. "While DigiLocker has established a robust foundation on the supply side issuing official documents like Aadhaar, PAN, driving licenses, and academic certificates, the aim is to now ensure organic adoption on the demand side across millions of daily commercial and institutional interactions. The initial focus is on high-volume, document-heavy sectors such as financial services, education and health," an official said.

For the same, Indian generative AI platform provider CoRoVer and global IT infrastructure services company Kyndryl are among the companies who have crossed the initial rounds, and are now being technically evaluated, he added. Under a new performance-based model, selected partners will earn per successful transaction, with payouts triggered only after meeting a minimum monthly volume threshold. "Payments kick in only when a requester hits a minimum monthly transaction threshold. Under the Digital Personal Data Protection (DPDP) regime, agencies must legally ensure zero retention, storage, caching, profiling, or secondary analytics of any document data fetched through DigiLocker," the official added.

Officials said MeitY is also working with state governments to identify sectors where DigiLocker integration remains low. "There are thousands of separate state and central government agencies providing one or multiple services requiring documentation. Some states have taken the lead to expand the ecosystem. Rajasthan provides family Register Jan Aadhaar with DigiLocker to more than 7.5 crore citizens, while Karnataka has on-boarded more than 75% of all government e-services," the official said.

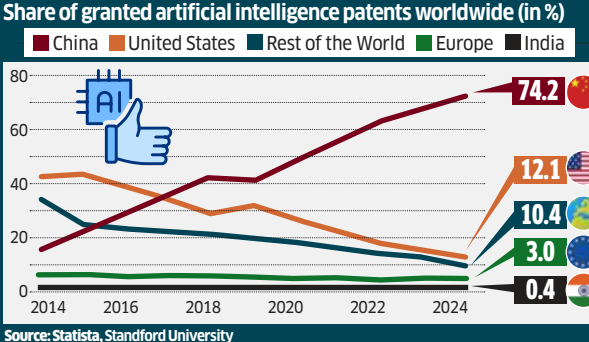
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Tech Trotter

Meanwhile in tech...

China is Pulling Ahead in Global AI Innovation Race



AI Agents Tried to Hack a Canadian Govt Website

WASHINGTON: An AI research firm has said AI agents tried to hack into a Canadian government website, casting the effort as a failed hacking attempt, while Canada said there were no indications its systems were compromised. Translucence said the attempts exhibited tactics "consistent with prior observed agent activity that we have attributed to OpenAI in a similar timeframe." —Reuters

Bessemer Names Ex-Elevation Exec Mayank Khanduja as its India Partner

Our Bureau



New Delhi: Mayank Khanduja, a former partner at Elevation Capital, has joined Silicon Valley-based venture capital firm Bessemer Venture Partners as a partner in its India team, the firm said in a statement on Wednesday.

ET had first reported on July 31 that Khanduja was in advanced discussions to join Bessemer.

Khanduja, who left Elevation Capital in January, will focus on early-stage investments at Bessemer, working with founders from their first institutional funding round, the firm said.

During his stint at Elevation, Khanduja led investments in various startups, including ShareChat, NoBroker, PlaySimple Games, Loop Health, Atlys and FRND. He also led the firm's investments in deeptech and manufacturing startups such as aerospace components maker Jeh Aerospace and General Autonomy, a robotics startup founded by two cofounders of ShareChat.

"India is producing a generation of founders building with real conviction, and the earliest stages are where an investor can be most useful. Bessemer's research-led approach and long track record make it the ideal platform to partner with these founders from day one, and I look forward to the journey ahead," Khanduja said. With Khanduja's appointment, Bessemer's India team now has five partners: Vishal Gupta, Anant Vaidur Puri, Nithin Kaimal, Pankaj Mitra and Khanduja. Bessemer, which has backed Indian companies including Swiggy, Urban Company and Sarvam, opened its India office nearly two decades ago.

The firm launched its first India-focused fund in 2021 with a corpus of \$220 million and followed it with a \$350 million India Fund II in March 2025.

Mayank Khanduja

IPO-bound Kuku in the Black, FY26 Revenue Up 6x

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Kuku Technologies, the parent of audio storytelling platform Kuku FM and microdrama app Kuku TV, swung to a profit in FY26 as operating revenue jumped more than sixfold ahead of its IPO (initial public offering).

The company reported revenue from operations of ₹1,484.2 crore, up 514% from ₹241.6 crore a year earlier, per its audited financial statements. Net profit stood at ₹182.7 crore compared with a loss of ₹152.6 crore in FY25.

The bottomline, however, was boosted by a deferred tax credit of ₹98.2 crore. This was due to Kuku's recognition of deferred tax assets against accumulated losses and depreciation, based on projections of future taxable profits. Profit before tax stood at ₹88.6 crore, compared with a pre-tax loss of ₹152.6 crore a year earlier. The turnaround came despite a sharp increase in customer acquisition costs as the company scaled its microdrama platform Kuku TV.



The company earned ₹1,475.4cr from subscription fees

RAJESH KUMAR PATHAK
Secretary, Technology Development Board



Our position is very clear. There is no dearth of funds. We have released whatever the applicant requested

viewed 51 and approved 22. Another 73 were listed as under review. The board received 35 proposals in February, 62 in March and 27 in April. By April 30, TDB had approved funding of ₹2,192.32 crore for the 22 companies, against a total project cost of ₹4,743.99 crore. These are approved



amounts, not funds already released to the companies.

In May, TDB signed agreements with five companies—e-TRNL Energy, Dhruva Space, Ecosystem Research, Nocar Robotics and Endure Air Systems. The board made its first disbursement under the scheme by transferring ₹50 crore to Ecosystem Research. The remaining companies are to receive funding based on agreed milestones and funding requirements.

"There is a difference between fund allocation and fund release to the company," Pathak emphasised. "Whatever requests have come, 100% have been met. In fact, we are left with further funds in hand."

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Todd Boehly arrived promising to reshape the team. But fans and even his partners soon turned against him

— LADY GAGA, singer, in an advertisement for Japanese familyMart. The video, part of the chain's part-time worker Gaga working behind the counter, offering fried chicken to eat and tea. According to inside sources, roughly 30 per cent of the chain's stores are short-staffed. A spokesman said that featuring one of the world's most famous singers would attract and retain recruits at a time when Japanese businesses are competing to hire new workers.

Eight rules for eating out with kids



Experts say restaurants are ideal for children learning how to behave in social settings. Here are tips to ensure a positive experience for everyone

Emily Heil

Dining at restaurants is one of the joys of life, but even the most devoted parents can agree that kids can sometimes complicate the idyllic scene of a leisurely meal. Here are tips from parenting and dining experts to ensure the experience goes as smoothly as possible for all involved: Parents, diners, staff and the kids themselves.

1 Practice makes perfect
The bottom line: It's important to get kids used to dining in restaurants. "When you think about it, much of our adult lives are spent in these social situations where we gather in restaurants—business meals, first dates, whatever it is — [and] gaining those skills and being acclimated to that environment is a really important lesson for children," says Adam Reiner, a veteran of the restaurant industry.

2 Choose the right place
Picking a place that's right for your family means checking it out in advance. Some restaurants have specific age-limit policies; others don't but still might not be the most welcoming. That's not to say that any 'fancy' place is off-limits. Amanda Shulman, a restaurateur who has a two-year-old daughter, says she and her husband still seek out upscale dining but she does her homework first. "We took her to a fancy meal this summer, and I called them

ahead—I wanted to make sure it was okay," she says.

3 Open communication
Communication with the restaurant is key. That starts with including any children in the party size when booking a reservation. And if you need a highchair or booster seat, make sure they have it or can accommodate your own. "I would make notes on the reservation and say, 'We have children ages three and eight,'" Reiner says. "The restaurant may want to assign you a table that's in a quieter, more remote area."

4 Stay mindful
When you arrive, let your server know in advance that you might need the cheque early and just be friendly. Once you're there, understand that it's still your job, not the staff's, to keep an eye on your kid. "We always say that there are no bad kids, just bad parents," says Peter Pastan, who owns a family-friendly pizza spot.

5 Make an extraction plan
If a kid is melting down, the grown-ups should be prepared to leave. Maybe the child just needs a break, like a walk outside. But sometimes, you just have to call it a night. If two parents are around, it's easier—one can exit with the fussy kid and the other can either remain or get the cheque and pay. If you're with a group, you can tap out and promise to send your share later. If it's just you, let your server know that you need to leave. And if you're mid-meal, ask for the food to go. The ideal strategy is to order as soon as you get to the restaurant.

6 Involve the kids
Many restaurants won't bat an eye if you bring snacks from home. And involve the kids in the ordering process, whether that's asking them what dish they prefer or telling the server what they want. Kids' menus can be great, but see if the young diners want to try something new. "Kids are actually much

less fussy about what they eat than a lot of adults," Pastan says.

7 Bring low-tech entertainment
Some restaurants cater to the underage set with crayons and games. But parents might want to bring their own lo-fi distractions such as drawing materials or simple games. Screens in restaurants are divisive. They might be fine in some settings but they might not be the best choice. Parenting expert Janet Lansbury notes that with screens, kids learn that meals are something you 'check out' from. Reiner says, "Developing those habits and getting them acclimated to being comfortable in that setting, the sooner the better."

8 Show appreciation
If your kid has left crumbs on the floor or required more of the servers' time than an adult might, it never hurts to show a little appreciation in the form of an extra tip. Parents often worry that the staff will be automatically put out, but that's not always the case, says Reiner, who recalls being delighted by kids who ordered for themselves and asked questions about the menu.

— The Washington Post



Restaurateur Ayesha Curry says that "table manners are important" for her and her husband, basketballer Stephen Curry, to teach their kids

An evening of curated luxury



Shubhika Sharma, founder of Papa Don't Preach and Mahesh Kumar Gowda, founder of The Runway Edit and QPL

Conceptualised by MKJ Entertainment, the event fused fashion with luxe experiences

etpanache@timesofindia.com

Bengaluru's luxury, fashion and lifestyle communities came together for the inaugural edition of The Runway Edit (TRE), an experiential luxury platform hosted at Conrad Bengaluru. Conceptualised by MKJ Entertainment, the invitation-only event brought together nearly 250 HNIs, UHNIs, entrepreneurs, investors and cultural influencers for an evening celebrating fashion, craftsmanship, hospitality and premium experiences.

The evening's fashion highlight was a special showcase by Shubhika Sharma, founder and the creative force behind the Mumbai-based luxury label, Papa Don't Preach. Marking her 16-year design journey, the showcase featured 30 archival, iconic and signature looks, reflecting the label's distinctive maximalist, playful and unconventional interpretation of Indian fashion.

Adding to the glamour, Bollywood actress Riya Sen joined the models on the runway. The evening also featured a live performance by music director Anoop Shankar, curated luxury-brand activations and a four-course fine-dining experience.

A new chapter in luxury
KNS Infrastructure presented



Actress Riya Sen

The Runway Edit as the title sponsor, with iUSTUS, XTRA SQFT, Shakti Autocars, Diageo, Stok Beers and Radio City joining as partners across real estate, automobiles, lifestyle, celebration and media.

Mahesh Kumar Gowda, founder of The Runway Edit and Queens Premier League, said the platform was created to bring premium fashion, designers and an exclusive HNI and UHNI audience together through a distinctive experiential format.

KN Surendra, founder of KNS Infrastructure, expressed his pleasure, citing the company's successful association with Gowda and the Queens Premier League.

Surendra also highlighted the league's reported reach of over one billion views, which he said contributed to strong brand visibility and sales.

my picks



Krish Ramineni
co-founder of Fireflies.ai, speeds through podcasts at 2.5x and unwinds on the cricket pitch

Movie

MAIN HOON NA. I'M A HUGE FAN OF SHAH RUKH KHAN; I'VE SEEN ALL OF HIS MOVIES. I ALSO LOVE ALL OF TOM CRUISE'S MOVIES, SUCH AS THE MISSION IMPOSSIBLE SERIES.



Music

YOU CAN'T GO WRONG WITH BOLLYWOOD MUSIC FROM THE 2010S, FROM ROMANTIC SONGS TO DANCE MUSIC.



Podcast

ACQUIRED. IT'S ABOUT THE HISTORY OF VARIOUS TECH COMPANIES AND BUSINESSES AND THE STORIES OF HOW THOSE STARTUPS WERE CREATED.

Food

PAN-ASIAN, INDO-CHINESE, THAI, THAT SORT OF FOOD IS MY FAVOURITE. WHILE THE CARBS ARE NOT THE GREATEST, I LOVE THE SPICE.



Holiday

I'M A HUGE FAN OF LONDON JUST BECAUSE OF THE FOOD, THE WEATHER AND THE VIBE. I KNOW EVERYONE WILL DISAGREE, BUT IF YOU SPEND TIME IN NEW YORK, YOU'LL REALISE HOW LAID-BACK LONDON IS.



— As told to khushi.vora@timesofindia.com

Quote

"PEOPLE MIGHT NOT REMEMBER WHAT YOU SAID, BUT THEY REMEMBER HOW YOU MADE THEM FEEL." IT'S ALWAYS IMPORTANT TO TREAT PEOPLE WITH RESPECT BECAUSE YOU NEVER KNOW — WHAT GOES AROUND COMES AROUND.

more is more

Known during the 17th and 18th centuries for its soothing hot springs, Atami, a small seaside city a 40-minute train ride from Tokyo, surged in popularity after World War II for Japanese holidaymakers. The city centre filled with bars, cabaret and nightlife, all lit up by flashy neon signs. When Japan's bubble burst in the early 1990s, Atami's prosperity collapsed as well. Now, a new guard of entrepreneurs is investing in Atami and such spots, resurrecting the maximalism of 'Showa retro'. It references a period from the 1960s to the '80s, when mid-century modernism with warm colours, fabrics and bright signage.

Looking to the past

This decorative revival doesn't merely reflect a nostalgic yearning amid economic doldrums. It marks a return to a more analogue format of human connection during a

Japan's retro revival

Maximalism is making a comeback, driving tourism beyond the usual hubs

Loneliness epidemic. It is also a reaction against the corporatisation of casual hangouts and signals a renewed focus on preservation. "When people think of Japan, they picture *washitsu*", a traditional-looking room featuring paper screens and *tatami* floors, says Takuji Kitagawa, a marketing strategy specialist based in Tokyo. "Showa retro is something else



Atami is a seaside city 40 minutes from Tokyo

entirely — it has its own visual language that's genuinely distinctive on a global scale." It's an aesthetic of excess. "War, growth, the bubble and its collapse — in my many ways, Showa was the most eventful and alive stretch of Japan's modern history," Kitagawa says. The



most recognisable relic from Showa times may be the *kissaten* cafe, characterised by a baroque, individual aesthetic verging on clutter.

A human curiosity

Keita Amano, an associate professor at Osaka Metropolitan University says that the upswing in Showa retro interest has to do with what he calls "light exoticism". We wonder how people in other places are living, and how others lived in the recent past, before the advent of certain technologies. These facets have sparked a surge in interest in *kissaten* and other Showa relics: Throwback *shotengai* (shopping arcades), *sento*

(elaborately tiled bath houses) and *dagashiya* (candy shops). Kitagawa says the record-breaking onslaught of tourists may be playing a large part. "Thanks to social media, everyday scenes that Japanese people have taken for granted for decades suddenly look soulful and evocative to the foreign eye," he notes. In 2025, Atami surpassed three million overnight visitors. Other leisure destinations around Tokyo are also seeing an analogous rise in nostalgic interest.

A 2025 analysis by the Japan National Tourism Organization found that 70 per cent of the country's visitors only visit five specific destinations: Tokyo, Kyoto and Osaka, plus Hokkaido for skiing and Okinawa for beaches. "But as foreigners begin visiting for the third or fourth time," Hewins adds, "the Showa retro aesthetic will soon be of great interest to them too."

— Bloomberg



Tulip and learn

As tulip planting time approaches, Amsterdam's Tulip Museum is well worth a visit for its best picks.

Tulipmania

The country grows over four billion tulips annually, but the flower is not native. Most tulips originate from the mountain regions of central Asia that made their way via the trade routes through Turkey and then Europe. The first tulip fanatics were the sultans of the Ottoman Empire. The name 'tulip' derives from the Turkish word for 'turban' because of its shape.

But it was in Amsterdam where 'tulipmania' occurred. The flower became a status symbol and frenzied speculation in 1636 led to a bubble that inevitably burst.

Spring pickings

Today, the fields of Holland are known for their dazzling rows of tulip flowers in spring. As tulip planting time approaches, the Tulip Museum's choice of varieties is on display.

There is a great range of species bulbs — smaller tulips that grow wild in their native areas, a good choice if you want your bulbs to naturalise. For example, 'Little Beauty' is from the mountains of Turkey and Greece. The long leaves lie flat on the ground and from them, on short stems, rich pink-purple blooms emerge in spring. If you plant these in pots or sunny borders they will come back every year.

'Angelique' is an old favourite, described as the 'Coco Chanel' of tulips with double two-tone soft pink flowers. It flowers in mid-to-late spring. 'Blue Diamond' is another beauty with its rich violet-blue double flowers.

While you may not start planting tulips until November, now's the time to buy your stock so you get your pick of the bunch.

— Daily Mirror



ID, PLEASE: How to spot a scam

None of these frauds are new. What has changed is the way AI is making these schemes more sophisticated and harder to detect

The phone rings, and it's your grandson's shaken voice. There's been an accident, he says, and he needs money before anyone finds out. Except it isn't him. It's a software that learned his voice from a clip posted online, run by a stranger working through a list of phone numbers.

For years, warnings about artificial intelligence and cybersecurity have focused on corporate networks and government systems. Those threats are real. But if you follow the money in the FBI's fraud data, a different picture emerges: Staggering sums are flowing out of household accounts.

In its 2025 annual report, the FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center began tracking complaints with an AI connection for the first time. Americans filed more than 22,000 such cases and reported roughly \$893 million in losses.

Old cons, new machinery

None of these scams are new. What AI changed is the cost and the quality of the cons.

Cloning a voice now takes a few seconds of audio and cheap consumer tools. In one study, listeners were able to identify an AI-generated voice only about 60 per cent of the time.

Video formats are heading the same way. In 2024, a finance employee at the architecture and design firm Arup was tricked into wiring about \$25 million to fraudsters after they set up a video meeting 'staffed' by deepfakes of the chief financial officer and several colleagues.

Phishing has improved, too. Clumsy wording and odd formatting used to give fraudulent emails away.

Language models now write clean, fluent messages and can personalise them at scale using details scraped from social media. Deepfake videos of well-known business figures pitch bogus trading platforms.

Why careful people fall for it

We'd like to believe that only careless people get taken. Research in behavioural finance says otherwise.

These scams are engineered around fear and urgency: A panicked grandchild, a boss demanding a same-day transfer, an investment window that closes tonight. Stress narrows attention and pushes people toward fast, intuitive judgments at the very moment they need slow, deliberate ones.

Fluency matters as well. A message with no typos in a voice that sounds exactly right sails past defences that a clumsy fake would have tripped.

Nobody plans to make a major financial decision mid-panic. That's exactly why scammers manufacture the panic.

The quiet version of the attack

AI-enabled theft doesn't necessarily involve talking to the victim. Stolen personal data sells for a few dollars on dark web markets. Criminals then feed it to automated AI agents that probe bank and fintech systems around the clock, testing credentials and hunting for weak points at a speed no human crew could match.

When an attacker gets into a customer's account, the takeover can be completed in minutes. Instant payment platforms, built for speed

and convenience, become the getaway car. The money typically moves within minutes and getting it back is almost impossible.

How to protect yourself and loved ones

Banks defend their own wire rooms with procedures, not vigilance. Households can borrow those procedures.

1 Check by calling back

When you get a suspicious call, hang up and dial a number you already know like your bank's fraud hotline and never one the caller or message supplies. The point is to leave the channel the scammer controls.

2 Trust and verify

You should agree on a family code word for emergencies and treat any request for money that lacks it as fake. Require two people in your household to sign off on any large

transfer, so nobody moves serious money alone and under pressure. And build in a delay, such as a self-imposed 24-hour wait, before any big payment.

3 Add layers of protection

Protect the accounts themselves, too. Turn on two-factor login for financial accounts and never share a verification code with someone who contacts you. You should also switch on your bank's transaction alerts, so a takeover announces itself in minutes, and consider a credit freeze, which is free and blocks thieves from opening new accounts with data bought on the dark web.

— PTI

Driving innovation

Shakti Group celebrates 70 years of success across varied sectors



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The Shakti Group, a name synonymous with strength, courage and dignity, has evolved into a powerhouse in the automotive, consumer lifestyle and hospitality sectors. With a rich legacy spanning over 70 years, the group has continuously adapted to changing market dynamics while upholding its core values of transparency, excellence and customer satisfaction.

Steady evolution

The foundation of the Shakti Group was laid in 1950 with the establishment of a garments manufacturing and retail business. In 1985, under the visionary leadership of chairman Narayanrao B Tatuskar, the business diversified into cattle feed manufacturing under the name 'Shakti Feeds'. This transition marked the beginning of a legacy where all subsequent businesses carried the

The group has adapted to changing market dynamics while upholding its core values of transparency, excellence and customer satisfaction

name 'Shakti', symbolising strength and resilience.

Shifting gears

A major breakthrough came in 2006 when the group transitioned entirely into the automotive sector, dissolving its cattle feed business to focus on the distribution of Maruti Suzuki Genuine Spare Parts. Since then, the Shakti Group has grown exponentially, establishing a strong presence in retail, dealerships and services for leading multinational automotive brands such as Tata Motors, Toyota Kirloskar Motors and Jaguar Land Rover.

Exploring new horizons

In 2023, the Shakti Group expanded into the consumer lifestyle sector by securing a franchise for Tanishq and Mia by Tanishq Jewellery along with a dealership for Titan, Fastrack and Helios watches in KR Puram. Furthering its diversification, the Shakti Group entered the hospitality industry in 2025 with the launch of its first Airbnb, 'Luxury Stays by Shakti', offering a premium stay experience in Goa.

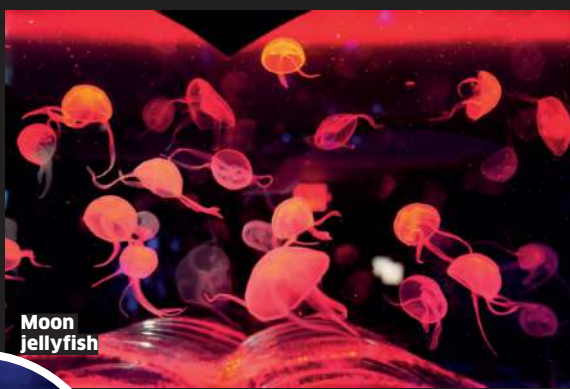
Visionary leadership

Today, under the leadership of chairman and managing director Venkatesh Tatuskar, along with executive directors Aditya Tatuskar and Pratik Tatuskar, director Geetha Tatuskar and brand director Nidhi Tatuskar, the Shakti Group continues to expand, while remaining committed to its vision of excellence and innovation.

7,000 The number of humanoid robots that were sold worldwide last year for industrial and professional service use. The Bank of America Global Research estimates that 90,000 humanoid robots will be shipped this year and 1.2 million by 2030.

Flow state

The Jellyfish Museum in Pompano Beach, Florida, is the first museum in the US dedicated solely to the invertebrates, and one of the few in the world. It was created by Alex and Yana Yanovsky, who previously developed aquariums and the first jellyfish museum in Kyiv, before they fled Ukraine in 2022.



The floating tentacled predators pulse and swirl in hypnotic patterns in the dark museum space, lit primarily by images projected on

the walls and the glowing light from the tanks. Jellyfish have survived for over 500 million years, making them older than dinosaurs and even trees. Their ancient origins are part of their allure, along with their hypnotic, pulsing

movements. They have no heart or brain and are made up primarily of water, giving them a translucent look.

The nearly 900-square-metre museum houses roughly 20 unique species of jellyfish. Different species can be rotated through the museum's 21 tanks. Current occupants include Japanese sea nettles, moon jellyfish, spotted jellies and upside-down jellyfish, the last of which can be found among Florida's mangrove swamps.

— AP



Spotted jellyfish



Papua jellyfish

PICS: AP

Shearing sheep shields Swiss snow

As Switzerland struggles to contain the shrinking of its Alpine glaciers, researchers are testing a new material on the Tsanfleuron Glacier: Sheep's wool. This summer's record heat has melted snow weeks earlier than usual, leading to more of the ice loss blamed for exacerbating rockslides.

In the summer, synthetic

Wool works as a natural alternative to plastic tarpaulins, which shed microfibres

tarpaulins are usually laid over ice and snow to reflect sunlight and reduce heat absorption. But plastic tarpaulins shed polluting microfibres. Project manager Timothee Steiner of the Keep It Wool project by Summit Foundation and the University of Lausanne, said the team wanted to explore a biodegradable alternative while finding a use for Swiss wool, 40-70 per cent of which is discarded each year. In June, two prototype blankets were laid on 200 square metres. Early results have exceeded expectations, showing that the wool covers limited melting as well as the synthetic ones. But only 0.02 per cent of Switzerland's glacier surface is covered by protective sheets. Scientists say reducing greenhouse gas emissions remains the only meaningful long-term way to slow the loss of ice.



A drone view shows a snow protection test site covered with sheep's wool material



Early results show that wool covers limit melting as well as synthetic ones

— Reuters



AI GENERATED

chip and dip

Doomers and boosters: Who's who in the AI wars

As bots reshape the world, a battle is raging between those sounding the alarm and those demanding faster progress

The furious debate over artificial intelligence has hardened into warring camps — and a cautious middle.

Here is a look at the battle lines in the war over a technology that is now the backbone of the economy and could decide the future of the planet.

The doomers

Fear of technology's dangerous consequences for society goes back far in history. OpenAI was founded in part because its backers, including first investor Elon Musk, feared that AI's development would end up in the hands of Google, which they believed could not be trusted with the technology.

Today, most of the doomers warning against the impact of artificial intelligence come from inside the companies themselves, from academia or both.

Those inside the industry are best represented by Dario Amodei, who co-founded Anthropic, now a major AI giant heading toward a historic IPO. He left OpenAI because he felt the Sam Altman-led company was not taking the technology's potential and dangers seriously enough.

His stance is decried as hypocritical, coming from a



widespread in Silicon Valley, but it is best represented by venture capital figures with considerable sway in the White House, such as Marc Andreessen, the influential head of venture capital firm Andreessen Horowitz, and David Sacks, the former White House AI czar.

Personally and philosophically aligned with tech figure Peter Thiel, the group is fundamentally opposed to regulation and battles behind the scenes and on social media against what it calls a well-financed doomsday 'cult'.

They accuse doomers of being a front for companies seeking to use regulation to crush rivals. Garry Tan, who runs the startup incubator Y Combinator, is



among the loudest of those voices, casting safety-driven regulation as a threat to the small companies that cannot absorb its costs. In the same go-faster camp is Jensen Huang, the CEO of Nvidia, whose chips are the bricks and mortar of the AI revolution — housed in the gargantuan data centres now meeting opposition across the world.

Proceed with caution

Many big tech companies try to proceed carefully, in a positioning more typical of large corporations that do not want to be caught on the wrong side of a political fight. At its founding in 2015, OpenAI was structured to ensure that researchers, and not investors, would have the final say on how the technology was deployed, with safety for humanity the guiding philosophy. But under Altman, who survived an in-house coup in 2023 led by safety-focused colleagues, the company now toes a more complicated line: Speaking to AI's dangers while still accelerating and cozying up to a no-holds-barred White House.

— AFP



Dario Amodei



Jensen Huang

company that is itself pushing out cutting-edge technology. Former Google researcher Geoffrey Hinton and fellow computer scientist Yoshua Bengio led the warnings about AI's threats in the months after the release of ChatGPT in 2022, which kickstarted the latest AI frenzy.

Build, build, build

Diametrically opposed to the doomers are the accelerationists, who believe in technology's advancement, its inevitability and its fundamental benefit for society — and who also make their fortunes on its success.

The ethos is



AI GENERATED

A man with dark, curly hair and a small earring is sitting, looking off to the side. He is wearing a grey pinstripe suit jacket over a black shirt with a white collar. The background is a plain, light-colored wall.

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